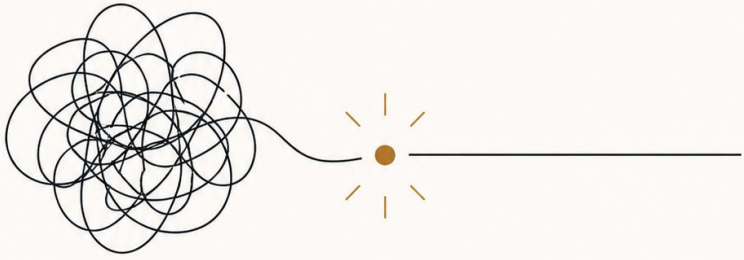
WEIGHT LOSS WITHOUT THE DRAMA



Small Changes. Less Effort. Better Health.

PRADEEP SOLANKI

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Book Overview

The weight-loss industry is massive.

There are countless diets, workout plans, apps and programmes, all promising results. And yet, many people remain stuck in the same familiar cycle:

Try hard → follow a strict plan → see some results → lose consistency → regain weight → feel frustrated → start again.

Over time, this can become exhausting—not only physically, but mentally.

This book takes a different approach.

It does not give you another strict diet, another rigid routine or another set of rules that you must follow perfectly. Instead, it looks at health from a wider perspective and asks a simple question:

What if lasting weight management has less to do with trying harder and more to do with understanding how your body and your life work together?

We will look at some basic areas that influence everyday health:

- Breathing
- Digestion
- Food and timing
- Movement
- Sleep
- Stress
- Joy

The book brings together simple insights from **Yoga, Ayurveda, classical texts such as the Bhagavad Gita, modern research, and everyday observations**.

The aim is not to make health complicated. It is to help you understand your body, make small practical changes and gradually build habits that can fit into ordinary life.

You do not have to change everything at once.

You do not have to be perfect.

And you do not have to live on a strict plan forever.

The book also looks at different situations—whether you want to lose weight for a particular goal, support your family, stay active as you grow older, or simply feel healthier in everyday life.

Most importantly, this book looks beyond the weighing scale.

Health is the goal. Weight loss is often one part of the journey.

The approach is simple:

Less pressure. More understanding.

Less perfection. More consistency.

Less drama. More life.

Why This Book

I did not come to yoga through a carefully planned career decision.

My journey started with a problem of my own.

I was overweight and not keeping well. I was also suffering from severe back pain, and the situation had reached a point where surgery was being considered.

I tried yoga.

What happened next changed the direction of my life.

As I practiced, I began to see changes in my health. Things that had troubled me started coming under control. More importantly, I experienced something I had not expected:

I felt the difference for myself.

That experience made me curious.

I wanted to understand yoga more deeply—not just as a set of exercises, but as a way of living.

I had a B.Tech in Computer Science and an LL.B., and I had spent many years in the IT and corporate world. But after experiencing the difference yoga had made in my own life, I decided to leave my corporate career and study and teach yoga.

Over the years, that personal journey became a professional one.

I have now spent more than 16 years working in yoga and wellness, with individuals, organizations and people from very different walks of life. I am also the author of *Mastering Corporate Yoga*, a book based on my experience of delivering yoga and wellness programs in the corporate world.

This is my first book on weight loss.

And it comes from a different place: my own experience, years of working with people, and my belief that health should fit into everyday life.

Through all these years, I kept noticing the same thing.

People were not necessarily short of information.

They knew they should exercise.

They knew they should eat better.

They knew they should sleep properly.

They knew stress was not good for them.

Many had tried diets, exercise programs and strict routines.

The problem was often something else.

They could not make these things fit into their lives.

A plan may work beautifully when everything is under control. But life is rarely under control for very long.

Work becomes busy.

Sleep gets disturbed.

Family responsibilities increase.

Energy changes.

Travel happens.

We fall sick.

We miss a day.

And once the plan breaks, many people think the answer is to start again—with more discipline, more restriction and more effort.

I began to question that approach.

What if the problem is not always that we are not trying hard enough?

What if we are sometimes trying in a way that was never designed to last?

That question is at the heart of this book.

I believe good health should not feel like another full-time job.

It should have a place in ordinary life.

It should work on busy days as well as quiet days.

It should allow you to enjoy a meal with your family, travel, celebrate, rest and occasionally have a bad day without feeling that everything has been ruined.

This does not mean ignoring discipline or doing whatever we feel like doing.

It means understanding the difference between **temporary control and sustainable change**.

The body is not something we need to constantly fight.

It is something we need to understand and support.

That is also why I have brought together ideas from different sources in this book. Yoga and Ayurveda offer a way of looking at health as a whole. Traditional texts offer perspectives on balance, discipline and living. Modern research helps us understand many of the processes involved in health, sleep, stress, metabolism and behavior. And everyday experience tells us what actually works, or doesn't work, when these ideas meet real life.

I am not suggesting that everything that worked for me will work in exactly the same way for everyone.

My experiences are my experiences.

The purpose of sharing them is not to say, **"Do exactly what I did."**

It is to say:

Perhaps there is another way to look at your own health.

You may not need another extreme plan.

You may need a better understanding of what can become part of your life and stay there.

That is the reason I wrote this book.

Not to give you more rules.

Not to make you feel guilty.

And certainly not to make weight loss another source of drama in your life.



Chapter 01 - The Endless Weight-Loss Cycle

Why most attempts start strong but don't last

The Beginning Feels Powerful

It usually starts with a decision.

"This time, I will do it properly."

You feel motivated.

You search for a plan.

You clean up your diet.

You decide to wake up early.

You begin exercising.

And for a few days…

everything feels right.

You feel in control.

You feel disciplined.

You feel proud.

The Plan Begins to Work

You follow everything strictly.

No sugar.

No junk.

No excuses.

You push yourself a little more every day.

And slowly…

you start seeing changes.

Maybe the scale moves.

Maybe your clothes feel lighter.

Maybe people notice.

And that feeling…

feels amazing.

You think:

"Finally. This is working."

So you continue.

For a while, everything seems to be going exactly as planned.

The Loop We All Know

Then life happens.

Work gets busy.

Sleep gets disturbed.

Energy drops.

Food starts feeling restricted.

And the routine that felt exciting…

starts feeling heavy.

One day you miss it.

Then another.

Then you say:

"I'll start again from Monday."

A Small Smile Moment

And somehow…

Monday has a habit of not coming.

Or it comes…

and quietly leaves again.

A Small Realization

If you look closely…

this is not a lack of effort.

This is repeated effort.

You have tried.

Again and again.

You woke up early.

You controlled your food.

You exercised.

You pushed yourself.

And still…

it didn’t last.

Which means…

the problem is probably not you.

It may be the approach.

When Effort Starts Feeling Heavy

The hardest part is not that it fails.

The hardest part is this:

You actually tried.

And when it doesn't last, what do we usually do?

We try again.

Maybe a stricter diet.

Maybe a tougher workout.

Maybe more discipline.

And for a while, we are back on track.

Until life changes again.

And the cycle continues.

Why This Cycle Keeps Repeating

Because many approaches are built on:

High effort.

Strict rules.

Perfect consistency.

And life…

does not work like that.

Life changes.

Schedules change.

Energy changes.

Priorities change.

But the plan does not always adapt.

So eventually…

it breaks.

And when it breaks, we often blame ourselves.

Then we start again.

A stricter plan.

A tougher routine.

More discipline.

And the cycle begins again.

A Simple Question

If something has not worked again and again…

is it time to try harder?

Or…

time to try differently?

A Final Thought

You are not stuck because you didn't try.

You have tried.

Perhaps the problem is that the approach was not designed to survive ordinary life.

Maybe you don't need more effort.

Maybe you need a better approach.

One that can live with your work.

Your family.

Your travel.

Your busy days.

Your difficult days.

And your ordinary days.

Because a plan that works only when life is perfect…

was never really a plan for life

Chapter 02 - Why Trying Too Hard Makes It Worse

When effort creates pressure instead of progress

There Is Nothing Wrong With Trying Hard

Most people who struggle with weight are not lazy.

They have tried.

They have changed their food.

They have exercised.

They have avoided foods they enjoy.

They have made rules for themselves.

They have woken up early and pushed themselves to do more.

So perhaps the question is not:

"Am I trying hard enough?"

Perhaps it is:

"Is the way I am trying something I can actually continue?"

That distinction matters.

When Discipline Becomes Pressure

There is nothing wrong with discipline.

Discipline helps us do things we might otherwise keep postponing.

The problem begins when discipline turns into constant pressure.

You decide:

"This time, I will be serious."

No sugar.

No outside food.

Strict exercise.

Strict timings.

No excuses.

For a few days, this can feel powerful.

You feel focused.

You feel in control.

You may even feel proud of yourself.

And sometimes, it works.

The problem is not that a strict plan can never produce results.

The problem is that a plan can produce results and still be difficult to live with.

That is an important difference.

When the Plan Becomes Your Whole Life

Imagine deciding that from today you will completely change the way you eat.

You remove everything you have decided is “bad.”

You start exercising more.

You wake up earlier.

You become very careful about every meal.

At first, the discipline itself can feel motivating.

Then a busy week arrives.

Work takes longer.

You sleep less.

Someone invites you for dinner.

You travel.

You are tired.

Nothing unusual has happened.

It is simply life.

But now the plan starts feeling like one more thing you have to manage.

The routine that made you feel in control begins to create pressure.

And when a routine demands more than your everyday life can comfortably give, maintaining it becomes difficult.

A Small Everyday Example

You decide:

"No sugar from today."

Suddenly, the tea you normally enjoy feels different.

Someone brings sweets to the office.

A family member orders dessert.

You were not thinking about sweets five minutes ago.

Now you are.

It almost feels like the world is testing you.

But it isn't.

Your surroundings, habits, preferences, emotions, sleep, schedule and energy can all influence what feels easy or difficult on a particular day.

That is why sustainability matters.

More Effort Is Not Always More Effective

When people feel that something is not working, the natural reaction is often to increase the effort.

Less food.

More exercise.

More rules.

More restriction.

More discipline.

Sometimes that may be appropriate.

But sometimes a better question is:

"Is this approach asking more from me than I can realistically continue giving?"

This is where the difference between discipline and over-effort becomes important.

Discipline helps you continue.

Over-effort can make continuing harder.

Try This for a Few Seconds

Clench your jaw.

Make your fists tight.

Raise your shoulders slightly.

Hold the tension for a few seconds.

Now let everything go.

Notice the difference.

The first state takes effort.

But holding that effort continuously is uncomfortable.

You would not want to spend your entire day with your jaw clenched and your shoulders raised.

The exercise is not a demonstration of how weight loss works.

It is simply an easy way to notice something about pressure:

Effort can be useful. Constant tension is not.

The same distinction is worth considering when we think about our health routines.

What Happens When the Approach Is Too Restrictive?

Very restrictive approaches can be difficult to sustain.

A sudden reduction in food can affect hunger and appetite.

A sudden increase in exercise can leave you tired.

A sudden change in routine can be difficult to maintain alongside work, family and everyday responsibilities.

The point is not that discipline is bad.

The point is that **more is not automatically better.**

A plan has to work not only on your best days…

but also on ordinary days.

Where Things Go Wrong

The problem is not effort.

The problem is:

excessive, sudden, unsustainable effort.

Plans that demand:

Perfect timing.

Perfect discipline.

Perfect consistency.

They may work for a short time.

But life is not perfect.

And when life changes…

the plan needs to be able to change with it.

Otherwise, the plan breaks.

And we are tempted to blame ourselves.

A Different Way to See It

Instead of asking:

"How do I push more?"

What if you ask:

"How do I make this easier to continue?"

Better sleep instead of deliberately sacrificing sleep for another workout.

Better food choices instead of constantly fighting hunger.

Better recovery instead of always adding more exercise.

A routine that fits your life instead of one that requires your life to fit the routine.

These may sound less dramatic.

But they are often easier to live with.

One Simple Realization

Trying harder is not always the answer.

Sometimes the better answer is to understand **what makes a healthy behaviour sustainable**.

You may need discipline.

You may need effort.

You may need to challenge yourself.

But you also need a routine that can survive:

a busy day,

a bad night's sleep,

a family function,

a work deadline,

a holiday,

or simply…

an ordinary Tuesday.

A Simple Question

If trying harder alone were the solution…

wouldn't it have worked already?

Perhaps it is time to stop asking:

"How can I do more?"

and start asking:

"How can I do this in a way I can keep doing?"

A Final Thought

Trying harder is easy to understand.

Trying differently requires more thought.

The goal is not to remove effort from your life.

It is to remove **unnecessary struggle**.

Because the best routine is not necessarily the hardest one.

It is the one you can continue.

And when something becomes part of ordinary life…

it has a chance to stay there.

Without extremes.

Without unnecessary pressure.

Without drama.



Chapter 03 - Breathe to Burn

The most ignored process in weight loss is happening right now

A Truth That Most People Don't Know

Most people think about weight loss in terms of food and exercise.

Eat less.

Exercise more.

Burn calories.

Sweat.

But there is something else happening every moment of the day.

You are breathing.

And there is an interesting connection between breathing and the way the body uses stored fat.

When the body breaks down and oxidises stored fat for energy, the carbon from that fat ultimately leaves the body largely as **carbon dioxide through the breath**, with the remainder leaving in other forms, including water.

That does **not** mean that taking deeper breaths or doing breathing exercises will automatically burn more fat.

This distinction is important.

Fat metabolism produces carbon dioxide.

Breathing removes carbon dioxide.

Breathing is part of the process of life and metabolism.

But breathing exercises are not a magic shortcut for weight loss.

So why does breathing deserve a place in a book about health and weight?

Because breathing is something we do all day—and yet most of us rarely pay attention to how we are breathing.

What We Usually Ignore

When people want to lose weight, they often focus on:

Joining a gym.

Walking or running.

Counting calories.

Changing their food.

Trying to burn more.

All of these can have their place.

But another process is happening thousands of times a day that we rarely notice:

Breathing.

Think about your ordinary day.

You wake up.

You pick up your phone.

You sit at your desk.

You attend meetings.

You drive.

You look at screens.

You rush from one thing to another.

And through all of it, your breath is with you.

You don't have to remember to breathe.

But you can learn to **notice your breathing**.

And that small shift—from breathing automatically to becoming aware of the breath—is where yoga has something valuable to offer.

What Yoga Knew About the Breath

Yoga has never treated the breath as merely a mechanical process.

Traditional yogic teachings connect the breath with the mind.

One well-known verse says:

"चले वाते चलं चित्तं, निश्चले निश्चलं भवेत्।"

The traditional teaching is often understood as:

When the breath is unsteady, the mind is unsteady.

When the breath becomes steady, the mind becomes steady.

There is a beautiful simplicity in this idea.

Modern science and traditional Yoga do not always use the same language to describe what happens in the body.

We don't need to force them to say the same thing.

We can simply appreciate what the yogic tradition has been asking people to observe for centuries:

Pay attention to your breath, and notice what happens to your experience.

Breathing the Yogic Way

Yoga also offers specific ways of working with the breath.

In the Bihar School of Yoga tradition, **complete or yogic breathing** is taught as a conscious, coordinated way of breathing. One important reference is *Asana Pranayama Mudra Bandha* by **Swami Satyananda Saraswati**.

In this approach, the breath is experienced in three stages:

First — the abdomen expands.

Then — the rib cage expands.

Finally — the upper chest expands.

During exhalation, the movement reverses:

Upper chest relaxes → ribs return → abdomen gently moves in.

The idea is not to force a huge breath.

It is to experience the breath as a smooth and connected movement.

This is a **traditional yogic practice**, and different people may experience it differently.

Try It

Sit comfortably.

Place one hand gently on your abdomen.

Slowly inhale, allowing the abdomen to expand first.

Then allow the ribs to expand.

Then allow the upper chest to participate.

Now exhale slowly.

Let the upper chest relax, followed by the ribs, and then allow the abdomen to gently move inward.

Repeat five times.

Don't force the breath.

Don't try to make it perfect.

Just experience it.

You may feel calmer.

You may feel more settled.

Or you may notice very little.

That's fine too.

The purpose is not to prove a theory.

It is to experience a traditional yogic approach to breathing.

A Small Practice You Can Carry Anywhere

You don't need a separate hour for breathing.

You don't need a special room.

You don't even need a yoga mat.

You can pause for a few breaths while:

- sitting at your desk
- waiting for someone
- travelling
- lying down
- taking a quiet break

Simply notice:

How am I breathing?

Is the breath rushed?

Is it comfortable?

Are you holding your breath without realising it?

Can you allow the next breath to become a little slower and easier?

You don't have to control every breath.

Sometimes awareness itself is enough.

So, Does Breathing Burn Fat?

Here is where we need to be precise.

Your body uses stored fat as fuel during metabolism, and carbon from that fat eventually leaves the body largely through exhaled carbon dioxide.

But that does **not** mean:

"Breathe more and lose more weight."

You cannot simply breathe deeply for ten minutes and expect it to replace movement, appropriate food choices or other aspects of healthy living.

The interesting lesson is different.

We often think of weight loss only in terms of what goes **into** the body and what we do to **exercise** the body.

But health is a much bigger picture.

Breathing is one part of that picture.

And Yoga gives us something more than a biological explanation.

It gives us a way to **work with the breath consciously**.

The Breath as a Pause

There is another reason I want you to notice your breath.

Life is fast.

We eat quickly.

We work quickly.

We respond quickly.

Sometimes we even react before we have had time to think.

The breath gives us a tiny pause.

One slow breath before eating.

One conscious breath before responding.

A few comfortable breaths when you feel rushed.

These moments may seem insignificant.

But they create something valuable:

a moment in which you notice yourself.

And sometimes, that is where a healthier choice begins.

Not with another rule.

Not with another restriction.

Just with a pause.

Let Your Breath Become Part of Your Health

You do not have to turn breathing into another task on your already crowded to-do list.

You are already doing it.

The invitation is simply to become a little more aware of it.

Practise a few comfortable breaths in the morning.

Pause before a meal.

Notice your breathing when you are sitting at your computer.

Use the yogic breathing practice when you have a quiet moment.

No competition.

No forcing.

No need to do it perfectly.

Breathe.

Notice.

Pause.

That may sound very small.

But health is often built through things we are willing to repeat.

And your breath is with you all day.

Perhaps it is time we started paying attention to it.

Because sometimes the first step toward changing how we live is simply becoming aware of how we are living right now.

Chapter 04 - Agni: Understanding Your Digestive Fire

What Ayurveda teaches us about digestion, food and health

We often think about weight loss in terms of what we should eat.

What should I eat for weight loss?

What should I eat for fatty liver?

What should I eat for my stomach?

What should I eat for better digestion?

What should I eat for more energy?

The questions keep changing.

And every question seems to have a new answer.

A new food.

A new powder.

A new seed.

A new drink.

A new supplement.

A new "superfood."

But Ayurveda invites us to look at something deeper.

Not only **what we eat**, but **how we digest and process what we eat**.

This is where the Ayurvedic concept of **Agni** becomes important.

Agni — The Digestive Fire

In Ayurveda, **Agni** is described as the digestive fire—the principle through which the body processes what we consume.

The word *Agni* literally means **fire**.

Think about an ordinary fire.

If it is burning properly, it can transform what is placed into it.

If it is too weak, things may not burn properly.

If it is too strong, things may be consumed very quickly.

Ayurveda uses this idea of fire to understand digestion and transformation within the body.

Agni is therefore not simply about whether your stomach is full or empty.

It is about how the food we consume is processed.

And this is where the Ayurvedic approach to health becomes interesting.

Because sometimes the question is not:

"What else should I add?"

It may be:

"What am I already asking my body to process?"

What Ayurveda Said Long Ago

Ayurveda expresses the importance of Agni very strongly:

"सर्वे रोगा अपि मन्दाग्नौ"

The verse means:
"All diseases arise from weak or impaired Agni (digestive fire)."

This is a traditional Ayurvedic teaching about the central importance given to digestion.

In simple terms, Ayurveda places digestion at the heart of health.

When digestion is disturbed, Ayurveda considers that the process of maintaining balance in the body can also be disturbed.

This gives us an important way to think about weight loss.

We often become obsessed with individual foods:

Is rice bad?

Is sugar bad?

Should I eat this seed?

Should I drink this juice?

But Ayurveda asks us to look at the **whole process of eating and digestion**.

How much are we eating?

How often?

How quickly?

Are we eating when we are genuinely hungry?

Are we eating more than our body needs?

Are we giving digestion enough attention?

These questions can sometimes be more useful than searching endlessly for the next "perfect" food.

Agni and the Bhagavad Gita

The idea of digestive fire is not limited to later Ayurvedic discussions.

The Bhagavad Gita also uses the powerful idea of **Vaishvanara**, the digestive fire within living beings.

The verse says:

अहं वैश्वानरो भूत्वा प्राणिनां देहमाश्रितः ।
प्राणापानसमायुक्तः पचाम्यन्नं चतुर्विधम् ॥

The verse means:

"Having become the digestive fire (Vaishvanara) in the bodies of living beings, I dwell within them. United with the incoming and outgoing breaths (prana and apana), I digest the four kinds of food."

The image is beautiful.

Digestion is described not merely as eating and filling the stomach, but as a process of transformation taking place within us.

Food enters.

The body processes it.

And what we eat becomes part of the living system.

For a person trying to lose weight, this gives us another perspective.

Instead of constantly asking:

"What should I add to my diet?"

we can begin by becoming more aware of the food that is already entering our body.

When Agni Is Disturbed

According to Ayurveda, when Agni is disturbed or weak, digestion is considered impaired and the body may accumulate what Ayurveda describes as **Ama**.

Ama is traditionally described as the result of improperly processed food or substances within the Ayurvedic understanding of digestion.

This idea gives us an important message:

Digestion matters.

We cannot look at food only from the outside.

A food may be considered "healthy," but that does not automatically mean we need unlimited amounts of it.

And this brings us back to something I have seen repeatedly.

People often ask:

"What should I eat?"

But sometimes the more useful question is:

"What should I reduce?"

Maybe You Don't Need Another Superfood

Today, there is an enormous market built around adding things to our diet.

Add this.

Take that.

Drink this in the morning.

Have this before sleeping.

Take this supplement.

Eat this seed.

Add this powder.

Try this superfood.

And when weight does not come down, we often look for yet another thing to add.

But perhaps our body does not always need another addition.

Perhaps sometimes it needs **less**.

Less unnecessary eating.

Less mindless snacking.

Less overeating.

Less eating simply because something is available.

Less dependence on complicated food rules.

This does not mean that every supplement or every special food is unnecessary.

It simply means that **adding more is not always the answer**.

Sometimes the first step towards better health is removing what we do not need.

A Pastry Can Teach You Something

Here is a very simple example.

Suppose you are looking at a pastry.

Your first thought might be:

"If I eat this, how many calories will I have to burn?"

So you start calculating.

How much walking?

How much exercise?

How many Surya Namaskars?

How hard will I have to work afterwards?

But there is another question you can ask **before** you eat it:

"Do I really want the whole pastry?"

Maybe you do.

Fine.

Maybe you decide to eat half.

That small pause changes the decision.

You are no longer thinking only about how hard you can work to burn the calories afterwards.

You are becoming aware of what you are about to eat.

This is not about fearing food.

It is about becoming conscious of food.

Because it is often easier to pause for a few seconds before eating than to create a large amount of exercise later simply to compensate for what we ate.

And that is a very practical part of the weight-loss journey:

Think before you eat, not only after you eat.

Eating Is More Than Choosing Food

Agni also gives us another way to look at the act of eating.

Eating is not simply:

Food → calories → weight.

There is an entire experience around food.

When do you eat?

How quickly?

How much?

Are you hungry?

Are you distracted?

Are you eating because you are bored?

Are you eating because everyone else is eating?

Are you continuing because the food tastes good even after you are comfortably full?

These questions do not require another diet chart.

They require awareness.

And awareness is something we can practise at every meal.

Before You Add, Become Aware

This is one of the simplest lessons I would take from the idea of Agni.

Before asking:

"What more should I do?"

pause and ask:

"What am I already doing?"

Before adding another supplement, look at the food you are already eating.

Before searching for another weight-loss food, look at how much you are eating.

Before adding another exercise session, look at whether your everyday eating is already more than your body needs.

Before creating another complicated health routine, look at the simple things you already know you could improve.

Sometimes the solution begins not with addition, but with reduction.

What Can You Observe?

You do not have to change everything at once.

For a few days, simply observe yourself.

Ask:

Am I eating because I am hungry?

Am I eating slowly enough to notice the food?

Do I regularly eat more than I need?

Do I continue eating even when I am comfortably full?

How do I feel after eating?

Am I constantly looking for something new to add to my diet?

There are no marks for getting every answer right.

The purpose is simply to notice.

Because once you notice a pattern, you have a choice.

The Ayurvedic Way of Looking at Food

Perhaps this is one of the reasons Agni remains such a powerful idea in Ayurveda.

It shifts our attention from individual foods to the **process of digestion and nourishment**.

It asks us to pay attention.

To eat with awareness.

To understand our own patterns.

To avoid unnecessary excess.

And to recognize that health is not always created by adding more and more things.

Sometimes it is created by allowing the body and our daily routine to do what they already need to do—more simply.

For someone trying to lose weight, this can be a powerful change in thinking.

Instead of constantly asking:

"What should I eat for weight loss?"

begin asking:

"How am I eating?"

And sometimes:

“What can I eat less of?”

One Simple Practice

At your next meal, do just one thing.

Before taking the first bite, pause for a few seconds.

Look at your food.

Notice how hungry you are.

Then begin eating.

Eat a little more slowly than usual.

Notice when you begin to feel satisfied.

You don't have to make the meal complicated.

You don't need a new diet.

You are simply becoming aware.

And that awareness can change the way you relate to food.

One Important Realization

Agni teaches us to look at digestion as an important part of health.

It reminds us that food is not simply something to count.

It is something the body receives, processes and transforms.

And perhaps the weight-loss question does not always need to be:

“What more should I do?”

Sometimes it can be:

“What can I reduce?”

Less excess.

Less mindless eating.

Less unnecessary complication.

More awareness.

More understanding.

More attention to what the body is already receiving.

Maybe the next step in your health journey is not another superfood.

Maybe it is simply learning to listen before you eat.



Chapter 05 - In the Sea of Diet Advice, Choose Wisdom

Not more diet plans — just better understanding

Ask ten people what you should eat to lose weight, and you may get ten different answers.

Eat more protein.

Avoid carbohydrates.

Try intermittent fasting.

Drink this.

Take that supplement.

Eat this superfood.

Don't eat after 7 p.m.

Then, a few months later, a completely different expert may tell you the exact opposite.

No wonder food has become confusing.

But food was never meant to be a mathematical problem alone.

Food is taste.

Food is culture.

Food is memory.

Food is family.

Food is celebration.

A meal can remind you of your childhood. A particular smell can take you straight back to your mother's kitchen. A festival can feel incomplete without certain foods.

So perhaps the answer is not another diet rule.

Perhaps we need a wiser way of looking at food.

And thousands of years ago, the **Bhagavad Gita** offered one such way.

What the Bhagavad Gita Says About Food

In Chapter 17, the Bhagavad Gita describes food according to three qualities:

Sattvic, Rajasic and Tamasic.

These are not simply three modern nutrition categories. They describe different qualities associated with food and the way it is experienced.

Let us look at what the verses say.

Sattvic Food — Food That Nourishes

The Bhagavad Gita says:

आयुःसत्त्वबलारोग्यसुखप्रीतिविवर्धनाः ।
रस्याः स्निग्धाः स्थिरा हृद्याः आहाराः सात्त्विकप्रियाः ॥

The verse means:
Foods that promote longevity, vitality, strength, health, happiness and satisfaction, and are nourishing, wholesome and pleasing, are dear to those of a sattvic nature.

This is a beautiful way of looking at food.

Food is not merely something that fills the stomach.

The question is also:

Does this food nourish me?

Does it support my energy?

Does it leave me feeling comfortable?

Does it satisfy me?

Does it fit naturally into my life?

For someone trying to lose weight, this becomes particularly useful.

Instead of constantly asking:

"What can I eat that has the fewest calories?"

we can also ask:

"What kind of food helps me feel nourished and satisfied?"

That does not mean every meal has to be perfect.

It means that foods associated with nourishment, freshness, satisfaction and wellbeing can form the **foundation of our everyday eating**.

If longevity, vitality, strength, health, happiness and satisfaction are what we want from life, these are qualities worth looking for in the food we eat.

Rajasic Food — Enjoy, But Control Excess

The Gita then says:

कट्वम्ललवणात्युष्णतीक्ष्णरूक्षविदाहिनः ।
आहारा राजसस्येष्टा दुःखशोकामयप्रदाः ॥

The verse means:

Foods that are excessively bitter, sour, salty, hot, pungent, dry or burning are dear to those of a rajasic nature and are associated with discomfort, distress and unease.

Notice an important word here:

Excessively.

The Gita is not simply saying that every spicy, sour or salty food is bad.

Indian food itself is full of flavour.

Spices, pickles, chutneys and strong flavours are part of our culture and our enjoyment of food.

The wisdom is in **control**.

A food may be enjoyable, but excess can change the experience.

Too much spice.

Too much salt.

Too much sweetness.

Too much of anything.

This is also useful when we think about weight.

You don't have to declare your favorite food forbidden.

You can learn to say:

"I enjoy this. I don't need so much of it."

That is very different from restriction.

It is control without fear.

Tamasic Food — When Food Loses Its Quality

The Gita says:

यातयामं गतरसं पूति पर्युषितं च यत् ।
उच्छिष्टमपि चामेध्यं भोजनं तामसप्रियम् ॥

The verse means:

Food that is stale, has lost its essence, is putrid, leftover or considered unfit is dear to those of a tamasic nature.

The message here is wonderfully practical.

Food should be fresh and wholesome.

Food that has clearly spoiled, deteriorated or lost its quality has no reason to become part of our regular diet.

So, if we were to turn the three qualities into a very simple everyday reminder:

Sattvic — MORE

Build most of your everyday eating around nourishing, wholesome foods.

Rajasic — CONTROL

Enjoy foods that are stimulating or excessive in quality, but keep them in balance.

Tamasic — AVOID

Avoid food that is stale, spoiled, putrid or clearly unfit to eat.

It is not about creating another rigid diet.

It is about becoming a little wiser about what we repeatedly put on our plate.

Food Is Not a Moral Test

There is another problem with modern dieting.

We often turn food into a moral test.

I ate a salad:

Good food. Good me.

I ate cake:

Bad food. Bad me.

Then comes guilt.

Then punishment.

Then a promise:

“From Monday, I will be perfect.”

And eventually the cycle begins again.

But food does not need to carry that much emotional weight.

Imagine a birthday.

Someone brings a beautiful cake.

You have a piece.

You enjoy it.

You don't need to spend the next morning punishing yourself for it.

One meal does not define your health.
Your overall pattern does.

A healthy relationship with food leaves room for celebration.

The goal is not to become afraid of food.

The goal is to become **less controlled by it**.

When Food Becomes a Solution for Everything

There is another pattern I have noticed repeatedly.

Whenever people have a health concern, their first question is often:

“What should I eat?”

For weight loss:

“What should I eat?”

For fatty liver:

“What should I eat?”

For better digestion:

“What should I eat?”

For the stomach:

"What should I eat?"

Then come the powders, seeds, drinks, supplements and superfoods.

Sometimes these may have a place.

But sometimes the better question is:

"What can I reduce?"

Less unnecessary snacking.

Less eating simply because food is available.

Less overeating.

Less highly processed food.

Less eating without noticing how much we are eating.

Sometimes health improves not because we added another special food, but because we stopped doing something that was repeatedly working against us.

That is an important idea for weight loss.

You don't always need to find the perfect food.

Sometimes you simply need to **eat a little less of what you already know you are having too much of.**

The Pause Before You Eat

Think about a pastry.

You want one.

Instead of immediately saying yes or no, pause for a moment.

Ask yourself:

Am I actually hungry?

Do I really want the whole thing?

Would half be enough?

That tiny pause can change the decision.

You may still eat the pastry.

And that's fine.

But perhaps you realise that half is enough.

This is very different from saying:

"I am never going to eat pastries again."

One creates awareness.

The other creates a rule.

And rules can eventually become exhausting.

What About Calories?

Calories do matter in weight management.

But most of us think about them only from the other side:

"How much exercise will I need to do to burn this?"

Sometimes it is worth pausing before we eat and asking:

"Do I really want to consume all of this?"

If a food is very calorie-dense, trying to compensate for every extra bite with exercise can become an exhausting game.

A small pause before eating may sometimes be easier than trying to "work off" everything afterwards.

The goal is not to calculate every bite.

It is to become more conscious of the relationship between **what we eat and how much we eat**.

When You Are Confused, Look Around You

There is another piece of wisdom I find useful.

When we don't know what to eat, we often search for something exotic.

A new imported superfood.

A complicated diet.

A supplement with a fashionable name.

But sometimes the answer is much closer to home.

Look at what is fresh, seasonal and familiar in your own region.

Nature has already given every culture an enormous variety of foods.

Vegetables.

Fruits.

Grains.

Pulses.

Nuts and seeds.

Spices.

Traditional preparations.

The exact foods will differ from one region to another.

That is perfectly fine.

When confused, a simple principle can help:

Choose food that is fresh, seasonal and naturally available around you.

You don't always need to search far away for the next answer.

You Don't Have to Eat Perfectly

There will be days when you eat differently.

A wedding.

A festival.

A holiday.

A dinner with friends.

A family celebration.

Life will happen.

And that is not a failure of your diet.

Health is not created by one perfect meal.

It is created by the pattern you return to most of the time.

If one meal is heavy, the next meal does not need to become punishment.

If you eat more than you intended, you don't need to declare the entire day ruined.

Simply return to your normal way of eating.

No punishment.

No guilt.

No dramatic restart.

Just continue.

That may be one of the most important lessons in sustainable weight management.

A Different Question About Food

Perhaps we need to stop asking only:

“Is this food good or bad?”

Instead, we can ask:

“Is this food helping the kind of life I want to live?”

Does it nourish me?

Does it satisfy me?

Am I eating it because I am hungry?

Am I eating it because it is available?

Am I eating more than I need?

Do I enjoy it?

Do I feel comfortable afterwards?

And most importantly:

What does my overall pattern look like?

These questions are more useful than trying to find one perfect diet.

The Wisdom Is in the Pattern

The Bhagavad Gita gives us a way to look at food through qualities rather than simply through numbers.

Sattvic — nourish and make it the foundation.

Rajasic — enjoy, but control excess.

Tamasic — avoid what is stale, spoiled or clearly unwholesome.

Then bring that wisdom into ordinary life.

Eat your regional food.

Enjoy your seasonal food.

Celebrate with your family.

Have your favourite foods sometimes.

Notice when you are eating more than you need.

And don't turn every imperfect meal into a personal failure.

Food is meant to nourish life.

It is also meant to be enjoyed as part of life.

The goal is not to build a perfect diet.

The goal is to build a way of eating that you can live with.



Chapter 06 - When You Eat Matters

The body follows a rhythm — we often ignore it

The Question We Rarely Ask

When it comes to food, most discussions revolve around:

What to eat.

What not to eat.

How much to eat.

But there is another question we rarely ask:

When should I eat?

We spend so much time choosing the food that we sometimes forget that **timing is also part of eating.**

Think about a typical day.

Morning is rushed.

Breakfast is light… or skipped.

Lunch is quick.

Eaten between meetings, work or errands.

And dinner?

That often becomes the biggest meal of the day.

Late.

Heavy.

Unhurried.

And then we go to bed.

It feels normal.

Because so many of us live this way.

A Simple Observation

Notice how you feel after a heavy late dinner.

Perhaps there is:

Heaviness.

Sleepiness.

Sometimes discomfort.

And the next morning:

Less hunger.

A slower start.

A feeling that the previous meal is still sitting with you.

We rarely connect these experiences with **when** we ate.

But the body notices.

And sometimes, the simplest place to begin is not by changing the entire diet.

It is by noticing the rhythm of the day.

An Old Ayurvedic Principle: Eat With the Rhythm of the Day

Ayurveda has long given importance to **kāla — appropriate time** in relation to food.

It expresses the importance of eating at the right time:

“कालभोजनम आरोग्यकराणां प्रमुखम्”

The verse means:

Eating at the appropriate time is among the important foundations of health.

The idea is simple.

Food is not taken in isolation.

It is taken by a body that is moving through a day — waking, working, resting, digesting and sleeping.

So when we think about food, perhaps we should not look only at the plate.

We should also look at the **time of the day**.

When the Sun Is Strong

There is a traditional Ayurvedic idea that digestive strength follows the rhythm of the day.

During daylight, we are generally more active.

As evening arrives, activity begins to reduce and the body prepares for rest.

This is one reason Ayurveda places importance on eating more substantially during the active part of the day and keeping the evening meal lighter.

You don't have to accept this as a rigid rule.

Try something much simpler.

Observe yourself.

Compare two days:

One day when you eat your main meal earlier.

Another when dinner is late and heavy.

Notice:

How do you sleep?

How do you feel when you wake up?

Are you hungry in the morning?

Do you feel light or heavy?

Your own experience can teach you something.

A Simple Ayurvedic Reminder

Ayurveda also gives importance to the meal taken at night being lighter:

"रात्रौ लघुभोजनम्"

The verse means:

At night, food should be light.

It is a simple idea.

And perhaps that is why it is useful.

Our modern routine often does the opposite.

Light breakfast.

Quick lunch.

Heavy dinner.

Late eating.

Screens until midnight.

And then we wonder why the next morning does not feel quite right.

The sun has not changed.

Our habits have.

Eat When the Previous Meal Has Digested

There is another important Ayurvedic principle that deserves attention:

the next meal should come after the previous meal has been digested.

The idea is not that everyone must follow the same number of hours between meals.

It is about learning to recognize readiness for another meal.

Are you genuinely hungry?

Do you feel relatively light?

Has the previous meal settled?

Or are you eating simply because the clock says it is lunchtime?

This does not mean ignoring your body's needs or deliberately creating long gaps between meals.

It simply means that **the clock is not the only signal worth noticing.**

Your body has a rhythm too.

How Much You Eat Matters Too

Timing is important.

But timing alone is not enough.

Ayurvedic thought also gives importance to **quantity**.

And quantity cannot be reduced to one standard portion for everyone.

A person who spends the day physically active may need something different from someone who sits at a desk most of the day.

Age, activity, appetite, routine, the food itself and the circumstances of the day can all matter.

So rather than asking:

"What is the perfect portion?"

a more useful question may sometimes be:

"How much do I actually need?"

There is a difference between being comfortably satisfied and eating simply because food is available.

That difference is worth noticing.

Not Just When — How You Eat Matters Too

We have looked at **when** to eat.

We have looked at **how much** to eat.

There is one more part that is easy to overlook:

How do you eat?

Think about a meal eaten while:

checking your phone,

answering messages,

watching television,

working,

rushing between meetings,

or barely noticing what is on the plate.

Now compare that with sitting down and actually experiencing the meal.

Seeing the food.

Smelling it.

Tasting it.

Chewing it.

Giving yourself enough time to eat.

You don't need a ceremony around every meal.

Just slow down enough to actually know that you are eating.

Try something very simple at your next meal:

Put the spoon down between a few bites.

Chew comfortably.

Notice the taste.

Take a breath.

Then continue.

You may discover that you were eating faster than you realised.

Digestion Begins Before the Stomach

Digestion does not suddenly begin when food reaches the stomach.

It begins in the mouth.

We see the food.

We smell it.

We taste it.

We chew it.

Saliva mixes with it.

The body begins preparing for what is coming.

That is why the way we eat matters.

Rushed eating gives us very little opportunity to notice what we are doing.

Slowing down creates space to experience the meal.

And sometimes that alone changes how much we actually want to eat.

What Modern Research Helps Us Understand

Modern research gives us another interesting perspective.

Our bodies have internal biological clocks, commonly described through **circadian rhythms**.

These rhythms influence many functions throughout the day and night, including sleep, hormones and metabolism.

This has led researchers to look more closely at **when** people eat, not only **what** they eat.

The science is still developing, and meal timing is only one part of the larger picture.

But it gives us an interesting question:

Could our eating pattern work better when it respects the rhythm of the day?

That is worth exploring.

Not as another strict diet.

As an observation.

What Happens When Dinner Moves Earlier?

You don't need to change everything.

Try one experiment.

For a few days, if your routine allows it, move dinner a little earlier.

And perhaps make it a little lighter.

Then notice:

Sleep.

Morning hunger.

Morning energy.

How your stomach feels.

How you feel when you wake up.

Don't judge the experiment by someone else's rule.

Observe your own response.

If it works for you, keep it.

If it doesn't, understand why.

The goal is not to create another perfect routine.

The goal is to understand your own rhythm a little better.

A Rhythm, Not a Rule

This is important.

Meal timing should not become another source of stress.

Life happens.

There will be weddings.

Travel.

Festivals.

Late meetings.

Family dinners.

Unexpected plans.

Some days dinner will be late.

Some days your routine will be completely different.

That is life.

The purpose of understanding rhythm is not to become frightened of breaking it.

It is to create a pattern that works **most of the time**.

A healthy rhythm is more useful than a perfect timetable that you cannot live with.

You Don't Have to Change Everything

Perhaps your first change is simply this:

Don't make dinner the biggest meal of your day.

Or:

Try eating a little earlier.

Or:

Notice whether you are genuinely hungry before the next meal.

Or:

Put your phone away while eating.

Or:

Slow down your first five bites.

You don't need to change everything at once.

One observation can lead to another.

And gradually, you begin to understand your own relationship with food.

A Small Shift in the Way We Think About Food

We often think:

What should I eat?

Then:

How much should I eat?

But perhaps there are two more questions worth adding:

When should I eat?

and:

How should I eat?

Ayurveda brings attention to all of these dimensions.

What you eat matters.

How much you eat matters.

How you eat matters.

And when you eat matters.

Chapter 6 is simply asking us to pay more attention to that last one.

A Simple Daily Experiment

For the next few days, don't try to follow a perfect timetable.

Just observe.

Before eating

Ask:

Am I actually hungry?

Has my previous meal settled?

What time is it?

During the meal

Ask:

Am I eating slowly enough to taste my food?

Am I paying attention?

How much do I really want?

After the meal

Notice:

Do I feel comfortable?

Light or heavy?

Satisfied or still looking for something?

At night

Notice:

Was dinner early or late?

Was it light or heavy?

How did I sleep?

The next morning

Notice:

Am I hungry?

How is my energy?

How does my body feel?

You don't need to write a report.

Just notice.

The Deeper Lesson

We spend a lot of time deciding what to eat.

But food does not exist separately from the rhythm of our lives.

We eat during the day.

We eat when we are busy.

We eat when we celebrate.

We eat when we are tired.

We eat when we are travelling.

We eat before sleep.

So perhaps healthy eating is not only about finding the perfect food.

It is also about learning **when food fits naturally into our day**.

The ancient wisdom of eating with the rhythm of the day gives us one way to look at it.

Modern research gives us another.

And our own experience gives us a third.

Put them together thoughtfully.

Then ask:

What rhythm helps me feel better, eat more consciously and live more comfortably?

You don't need a perfect answer.

You only need to start noticing.

Because sometimes health is not about doing something more.

Sometimes, it is about doing the right thing at the right time.

Chapter 07 - Stress: The Silent Fat-Storing Signal

The body responds to the state you live in

Most people blame weight gain on food.

Too much food.

The wrong food.

Too many calories.

But there is another part of the picture that is often overlooked:

Stress.

Deadlines. Notifications. Unfinished work. Family responsibilities. Financial worries. Constant thinking. Poor sleep. The feeling that you are always "on."

Stress may not put food directly into your mouth, but it can change the way you eat, sleep, move and respond to cravings. Over time, that can make maintaining a healthy weight much harder.

And modern research is increasingly showing that chronic stress and stress-hormone signaling can influence several pathways involved in appetite, metabolism, weight regulation and fat storage.

So perhaps the question is not only:

"What am I eating?"

Perhaps sometimes we should also ask:

"What state am I living in?"

When Stress Looks Like Hunger

Have you ever had a difficult day and suddenly wanted something sweet?

Or finished a long meeting and immediately looked for a snack?

Or found yourself eating while working, scrolling or watching television without really noticing how much you had eaten?

Sometimes, the body is not asking for food.

It may be asking for **relief**.

Food is easily available. It gives pleasure. It gives us something to look forward to. For a few moments, it can take our attention away from whatever is bothering us.

That does not make you weak.

It makes you human.

The useful question is not:

"Why can't I control myself?"

It is:

"What am I really looking for right now?"

Perhaps you are hungry.

Perhaps you are tired.

Perhaps you are bored.

Perhaps you need a break.

Perhaps you simply need a few quiet minutes.

That small pause can sometimes change what happens next.

Stress Changes More Than Your Mood

When stress becomes a regular part of life, its effects are not limited to how we feel. It can disturb sleep, influence appetite and

cravings, reduce our motivation to move, and make healthy routines harder to maintain.

This is where stress becomes relevant to weight management.

Imagine someone who has been eating reasonably well but is sleeping poorly, working long hours, constantly worrying and reaching for food whenever the day becomes overwhelming.

Telling that person to simply "be more disciplined" may miss the real problem.

The problem may not be a lack of knowledge.

It may be **the state in which they are trying to follow the plan.**

When the Mind Never Gets a Pause

Our ancestors certainly experienced stress.

But modern life can create something different: **small stresses repeated throughout the day.**

A message.

A deadline.

A traffic jam.

A difficult conversation.

A notification.

A financial worry.

Another meeting.

Another unfinished task.

None of these may be a life-threatening emergency. Yet together they can keep the mind constantly engaged.

The body needs periods of activity, but it also needs periods of recovery.

That is why creating small pauses during the day can be more useful than waiting for one perfect holiday or one completely stress-free weekend.

A few minutes of walking.

Sitting quietly.

Looking outside.

Taking a few slower breaths.

Having a meal without a screen.

Going to bed a little earlier.

These may look insignificant.

But health is often built from small things repeated.

What Yoga Has Been Saying About Breath and Mind

Yoga has long paid attention to the relationship between breath and the mind.

The *Haṭha Yoga Pradīpikā* says:

चले वाते चलं चित्तं निश्चले निश्चलं भवेत् ।

When the breath is restless, the mind becomes restless; when the breath becomes still, the mind becomes still.

— *Haṭha Yoga Pradīpikā, 2.2*

The verse points to a simple observation: when the breath is agitated, the mind often feels agitated too; when the breath settles, the mind can begin to settle with it.

You do not need to turn this into a complicated practice.

Sometimes, simply noticing your breathing is enough to create a pause between **what happened** and **what you do next**.

Stress and the Weight-Loss Effort

There is another kind of stress we create ourselves.

We decide to lose weight.

Then we become strict.

We remove everything we enjoy.

We exercise intensely.

We try to follow every rule perfectly.

And when life inevitably disrupts the plan, we feel that we have failed.

Now we have two problems:

the original stress of life—and the stress of trying to lose weight.

This is why sustainable weight loss cannot depend on living under constant pressure.

A plan that works only when life is perfect is not much of a plan.

The better question is:

"What can I continue even when life gets difficult?"

Stress, Food and the Need for Relief

There is a simple experiment you can try.

The next time you suddenly want something to eat, pause for a moment.

Ask yourself:

Am I hungry?

If yes, eat.

But if you are not sure, ask:

"What do I really need right now?"

Maybe the answer is food.

Maybe it is a break.

Maybe it is water.

Maybe it is sleep.

Maybe it is movement.

Maybe it is simply five minutes without anyone asking anything from you.

You don't have to get the answer right every time.

The purpose is not to control yourself.

It is to **understand yourself better.**

You Don't Have to Remove Stress

Life will always have deadlines.

There will be difficult days.

There will be family responsibilities, unexpected problems, travel, work pressure and situations you cannot control.

So the goal cannot be:

"I must eliminate stress."

The goal is to give the mind and body enough opportunities to **come back down**.

Think of it like a rubber band.

It can stretch.

But it also needs to return to its natural state.

If it is kept stretched all the time, eventually something changes.

The same principle can be useful in everyday life:

stress, followed by recovery.

Work, followed by a pause.

Activity, followed by rest.

Attention, followed by quiet.

That rhythm matters.

Small Pauses Count

You don't need an hour of meditation to create a little space in your day.

Try something much smaller.

Before opening your next email, take one slow breath.

Before eating, pause for a few seconds.

After a difficult phone call, walk for two minutes.

Drink your tea without looking at your phone.

Step outside and look at the sky.

Go to bed instead of watching one more episode.

These are not dramatic lifestyle changes.

They are small signals to yourself:

I don't have to keep rushing.

And sometimes that is exactly what we need before making another health decision.

The Bigger Picture

Weight management is not happening in isolation.

You are not just a stomach counting calories.

You are a whole person—with thoughts, emotions, responsibilities, habits, relationships, sleep patterns and a life that continues while you are trying to become healthier.

Food matters.

Movement matters.

Sleep matters.

And **the state in which you live matters too.**

So the next time your weight is not changing as expected, don't immediately assume that you need another diet, another workout or another supplement.

Pause and ask:

How has my life been lately?

How have I been sleeping?

What has been stressing me?

Am I eating because I am hungry—or because I need a break?

Am I giving myself any time to recover?

You may discover that the answer is not always sitting in your kitchen.

Sometimes, it is hidden in the way you are living.

A Simple Thought to Carry

Don't only manage your food.

Pay attention to the state in which you eat, sleep, move and live.

Because sometimes, making weight loss easier does not begin with **doing more**.

It begins with giving yourself a little more **space to breathe.**

Chapter 08 - Sleep: The Most Underrated Fat-Loss Tool

The body repairs in rest, not in effort

When people think about weight loss, the usual conversation is familiar:

Food.

Exercise.

Calories.

Diet plans.

Sleep rarely gets the same attention.

Yet think about what happens after a poor night's sleep.

You wake up tired.

You may feel less energetic.

You may crave something quick and comforting.

Exercise feels like more effort.

Concentration becomes harder.

And by evening, you may simply want to sit down and eat.

Now imagine this happening not once, but regularly.

Sleep may not be the first thing you think about when trying to lose weight, but it can quietly influence many of the things that make weight management easier—or harder.

Sleep does not magically burn fat.

It helps create the conditions in which the body, mind and daily habits can function better.

Two Mornings

Think about two mornings.

On the first morning, you have slept reasonably well. You wake up feeling rested. You have enough energy to get through the morning. You can think clearly. You are less likely to depend entirely on caffeine or reach for food simply because you are exhausted.

On the second morning, you have slept badly.

You wake up tired. The day already feels longer than it should. Exercise seems difficult. Work demands your attention. By afternoon, you are looking for something to give you energy. By evening, you are exhausted but somehow still awake.

The difference may not be dramatic.

But repeated day after day, these small differences can affect how you eat, move and live.

That is why sleep deserves a place in a conversation about weight loss.

What Ayurveda Already Understood

Ayurveda gave sleep a much more important place than modern weight-loss conversations often do.

Among the three important supports of life, Ayurveda places:

Ahara — foodNidra — sleep

Brahmacharya — regulated conduct

Food is not the only thing that sustains us.

Sleep matters too.

One of the classical descriptions in the *Charaka Samhita* makes this connection beautifully:

निद्रायत्तं सुखं दुःखं पुष्टिः कार्श्यं बलाबलम्।
वृषता क्लीबता ज्ञानमज्ञानं जीवितं न च॥३६॥

Charaka Samhita, Sutra Sthana 21.36

In simple words, the verse connects sleep with happiness and unhappiness, nourishment and emaciation, strength and weakness, and several other aspects of life.

The message is remarkably broad:

Sleep is not simply rest. It is part of how the body is maintained.

And Ayurveda did not treat sleep as an isolated activity. It understood it alongside food and the way we live.

Sleep and Weight

There is another particularly interesting Ayurvedic reference:

देहवृत्तौ यथाऽऽहारस्तथा स्वप्नः सुखो मतः।
स्वप्नाहारसमुत्थे च स्थौल्यकार्श्ये विशेषतः॥५१॥

Charaka Samhita, Sutra Sthana 21.51

The verse places **sleep and food together** when discussing the maintenance of the body and specifically refers to **sthāulya** and **kārśya**—excessive bulk and emaciation.

We don't need to turn this into a complicated Ayurvedic lesson.

The simple wisdom is enough:

What you eat matters.

How you sleep matters too.

Modern research has also found associations between inadequate or disturbed sleep, appetite, food intake, energy levels and body weight.

The relationship is not a single simple mechanism. Sleep affects several systems and behaviors at the same time.

And that is precisely why it matters.

When Sleep Is Regularly Neglected

One poor night is not a disaster.

The problem begins when poor sleep becomes your normal pattern.

You sleep late because of work.

You wake early because of responsibilities.

You stay on your phone because you finally have some quiet time.

You tell yourself:

“I'll sleep properly on the weekend.”

Then Monday comes.

Over time, tiredness becomes normal.

And when tiredness becomes normal, we sometimes stop noticing how much it is affecting us.

The Late-Night Trap

There is a pattern many people know very well:

You work late.

You sleep late.

You wake up tired.

You have less energy.

You move less.

You may eat differently because you are tired.

You reach the evening exhausted.

And then, instead of going to bed early, you stay awake a little longer.

The cycle begins again.

This is why weight loss cannot always be solved by simply adding more discipline.

Sometimes the problem is not that you don't know what to eat.

Sometimes the problem is that you are trying to make good decisions while running on very little energy.

Sleep Changes the Next Day

Think about how different the same healthy plan can feel depending on how you slept.

A morning walk after good sleep may feel easy.

The same walk after a restless night may feel like a task.

Preparing a simple meal may feel manageable when you are rested.

After a tiring day, ordering something convenient may feel much easier.

This doesn't mean poor sleep makes healthy choices impossible.

It means we should stop pretending that the body and mind operate exactly the same way every day.

Your state matters.

This Is Not About Perfect Sleep

There is an important distinction here.

You do not need to sleep perfectly every night.

Life happens.

There will be late nights, travel, family responsibilities, deadlines, celebrations and restless nights.

The goal is not perfection.

The goal is to make **good sleep the normal pattern rather than the occasional luxury.**

That is a much more realistic goal.

Three Simple Things to Try

You don't need a complicated sleep protocol.

Start with something you can actually maintain.

1. Protect your sleep time

If you know you need around seven or eight hours, work backwards.

Don't wait until you are exhausted before deciding when to sleep.

Treat sleep as part of your daily routine, not whatever is left after everything else is finished.

2. Reduce late-night stimulation

Your last hour before bed does not have to be filled with messages, work, news, scrolling and one more video.

Dim the activity.

Put the phone away when you can.

Let the day become quieter.

Even a small change can make bedtime feel different.

3. Notice the next morning

This one is important.

Instead of judging your sleep only by the number of hours, observe what happens the next day.

Ask:

How energetic do I feel?

How hungry am I?

How easy does movement feel?

Am I craving food for hunger—or because I am exhausted?

You are not trying to create another rule.

You are learning about yourself.

The Weight-Loss Connection

We often imagine weight loss as a straight line:

Eat less → exercise more → lose weight.

Real life is rarely that simple.

Your sleep affects your energy.

Your energy affects your movement.

Your sleep and tiredness can influence appetite and food choices.

Your food choices affect how you feel.

And how you feel affects what you do next.

Everything is connected.

This is why sometimes the most useful question is not:

"What else should I do?"

It may be:

"What am I not giving my body enough of?"

For some people, the answer may be better food.

For someone else, it may be more movement.

And sometimes, surprisingly, it may be **sleep**.

Don't Turn Sleep Into Another Obsession

There is a danger even here.

You read about sleep and immediately decide:

"Now I have to get perfect sleep too."

Then you start checking the clock.

Tracking every minute.

Worrying about whether you slept deeply enough.

Feeling guilty after one bad night.

That defeats the purpose.

Sleep should support your health, not become another source of pressure.

Remember what we have been learning throughout this book:

Health should become simpler, not more complicated.

A Small Experiment

For the next seven days, don't try to transform your sleep.

Just observe it.

Notice approximately when you go to bed.

Notice when you wake up.

Notice how you feel the next morning.

Notice your energy.

Notice your hunger.

Notice your cravings.

Notice your willingness to move.

You may begin to see a pattern that was always there but that you never connected to your weight-loss journey.

And once you see a pattern, you can start changing it.

Not dramatically.

Just deliberately.

Sleep Is Not Lost Time

We live in a culture that often celebrates being busy.

Sleeping less can even feel like being productive.

But the body doesn't see it that way.

You cannot continuously borrow from your recovery and expect the account never to come due.

Sleep is not time lost.

It is time given back to the body.

So before you add another workout, another diet rule or another restriction, look at something much simpler.

Ask yourself tonight:

"Am I giving my body enough time to rest?"

Sometimes the next step in your weight-loss journey isn't doing more.

It is finally allowing your body to recover from what you are already doing.

Chapter 09 - Movement Is a Rhythm, Not an Event

The Missing Link in Weight Loss

When we think about movement, we usually think about exercise.

A workout.

A gym.

A yoga class.

A walk that we planned.

Something that starts at a particular time and ends at a particular time.

And if we don't do it...

we feel we did nothing.

But what if movement is bigger than exercise?

What if your body doesn't care whether you called something a "workout"?

What if what matters is that you moved?

Throughout the day.

Again and again.

Naturally.

A Common Belief

Ask someone:

"Did you exercise today?"

The answer is usually easy.

Yes.

Or no.

But ask a different question:

“How much did you move today?”

That answer is much harder.

Because movement is happening all the time.

You walk to the kitchen.

You stand up from your chair.

You walk to the washroom.

You climb a few stairs.

You carry something.

You stretch because your back feels stiff.

You walk while talking on the phone.

You stand while waiting.

You move around your home.

You walk across the office.

None of these may feel like exercise.

But they are still movement.

And that changes the question.

Instead of asking:

“Did I exercise?”

perhaps we can sometimes ask:

“How much movement found its way into my day?”

Movement Was Never Meant to Be One Event

Our modern lives have made movement strangely formal.

We sit for hours.

Then we decide we need to exercise.

So we go somewhere and move intensely for thirty or forty-five minutes.

Then we return to sitting.

There is nothing wrong with structured exercise.

It has an important place.

Strength, cardiovascular fitness, mobility and physical capacity cannot always be replaced by a few casual movements during the day.

But structured exercise is not the only movement your body receives.

Your day itself can contain movement.

Small amounts.

Frequent amounts.

Ordinary amounts.

That is the idea behind this chapter.

Movement is not an event.

It is a rhythm.

Look at Your Day Again

From morning to night, how many moments do you spend waiting?

Waiting for the lift.

Waiting at a signal.

Waiting for someone to arrive.

Waiting for a meeting to begin.

Sitting during a phone call.

Watching television.

Waiting for your tea or coffee.

Standing in the kitchen.

Moving from one room to another.

These moments are usually treated as empty time.

But some of them can become movement opportunities.

Not every one.

Not mechanically.

Not because you must burn calories every time you have thirty seconds.

Simply because you are already there.

And your body is already there with you.

You Don't Always Need Extra Time

This is where the idea of small habits becomes useful.

We often think:

“When I get time, I will exercise.”

But life rarely gives us a completely empty hour.

There is always work.

Family.

Travel.

Messages.

Meetings.

Unexpected things.

So instead of waiting for an empty space in the day, look at the spaces that already exist.

You don't necessarily need a new routine.

You can sometimes use your existing routine differently.

That is a much smaller change.

And small changes are often easier to repeat.

The First 10 Minutes of Your Day

What is the first thing many people do after waking up?

Pick up the phone.

Scroll.

Check messages.

Read notifications.

Perhaps check email.

Same ten minutes.

Every day.

Now imagine a small shift.

Drink some water.

Sit for a moment in a natural, comfortable posture such as **Kāka Āsana**, if it is comfortable and appropriate for you.

Take a few quiet breaths.

Move gently.

Then use your phone if you want.

Same ten minutes.

But a different beginning.

You haven't added an hour of exercise.

You haven't created another demanding routine.

You simply changed what happened inside ten minutes that already existed.

That is the idea.

Don't always look for more time.

Look at the time you already have.

The Invisible Shift

Real change does not always look dramatic.

Sometimes it looks like:

standing instead of sitting,

walking instead of waiting,

taking the stairs when practical,

stretching after sitting for a long time,

walking while having a phone conversation,

getting up between long periods of screen time,

or simply changing your posture because you have noticed that you have been sitting in one position for too long.

None of these needs to become a performance.

You don't have to count every movement.

You don't have to turn your entire day into an exercise program.

The purpose is awareness.

You begin to notice opportunities that were always there.

A Small Pause

Try something now.

Stand up.

Roll your shoulders gently.

Move your arms.

Stretch upwards.

Take a few comfortable steps.

Thirty seconds.

That's it.

You may feel a little warmer.

A little more awake.

Perhaps nothing dramatic happens.

That's fine.

The point isn't that thirty seconds has transformed your health.

The point is that you have interrupted stillness.

And once you begin noticing these moments, they become easier to create.

Small Moments Add Up

One small movement may not seem important.

And it isn't meant to.

The mistake is expecting every action to produce a visible result immediately.

A few extra steps won't transform your body overnight.

One stretch won't undo a day of sitting.

One minute of movement isn't a substitute for all the physical activity your body needs.

But repeated movement is different.

A few minutes here.

A little walking there.

Standing up.

Taking the longer route.

Moving between tasks.

A short walk after a long period of sitting.

Over a day, these moments can become part of your overall activity.

And over weeks and months, the pattern matters more than any single moment.

This is one reason the modern concept of **NEAT—non-exercise activity thermogenesis**—has become useful in understanding daily energy expenditure.

The technical term is not important for you to remember.

The simple idea is:

Your body uses energy not only during planned exercise, but also through the ordinary physical activity of daily life.

So don't underestimate ordinary movement.

But don't misunderstand it either.

Small movement complements exercise. It does not make structured exercise unnecessary.

There is room for both.

The One-Minute Principle

Sometimes the barrier is not physical.

It is psychological.

We think:

“If I can't do thirty minutes, there is no point.”

So we do nothing.

What if we changed that?

One minute is not a workout.

It doesn't need to be.

It is simply a way of keeping movement present.

Stand.

Walk.

Stretch.

Move your shoulders.

Take a few comfortable steps.

Then continue with your day.

The value is not that one minute burns a meaningful number of calories.

The value is that **one minute can be easier to repeat than thirty minutes you keep postponing.**

That is where consistency begins.

Use the Moments That Already Exist

You don't need to redesign your entire day.

Look at what you already do.

After sitting for a long time

Stand up.

Walk for a few minutes.

Stretch gently.

During a phone call

If the situation allows, stand or walk instead of sitting.

While waiting

If you are comfortable, move your ankles, change position or simply stand rather than remaining seated unnecessarily.

Between tasks

Instead of moving immediately from one chair to another, take a short walk.

At home

Walk around while doing small household tasks.

Carry things yourself when practical.

Move between rooms rather than trying to do everything from one place.

During screen time

Take regular opportunities to stand and change position.

None of these is compulsory.

The point is not to turn life into a fitness test.

The point is to stop treating every ordinary movement as meaningless.

Not Intensity. Consistency.

Another simple idea:

“अर्धशक्त्या व्यायामः”

Move within your capacity.

Not till exhaustion.

Not till you avoid it.

The Ayurvedic tradition gives importance to exercising according to one's capacity rather than treating exhaustion as the goal.

That is a remarkably useful idea in a world where exercise is often presented as:

harder.

faster.

more.

burn more.

But more is not automatically better.

The right amount depends on the person.

Age matters.

Fitness matters.

Health matters.

Experience matters.

And the body's condition on that particular day matters too.

A sustainable relationship with movement is not built by proving how much you can tolerate.

It is built by finding an amount you can continue.

Don't Turn Movement Into Another Punishment

Some people exercise because they enjoy it.

Others exercise because they believe they have to compensate for what they ate.

“I had dessert, so I have to walk.”

“I missed yesterday, so I need to work harder today.”

“I ate too much, so I need to burn it off.”

Slowly, movement becomes punishment.

And once movement becomes punishment, it becomes much harder to love—or even continue.

This chapter is not asking you to stop exercising.

It is asking you to change the relationship.

Exercise can build strength.

Walking can clear your head.

Stretching can feel good after sitting.

Movement can be useful simply because your body enjoys changing position.

You don't have to earn food through exercise.

You don't have to punish yourself for eating.

And you don't have to exhaust yourself to prove that you are serious about your health.

The Day Is Your Movement Plan

Perhaps this is the simplest way to think about it.

Instead of:

“When will I exercise?”

ask:

“Where can movement naturally fit into my day?”

Morning.

Between tasks.

During a break.

On the way somewhere.

After sitting.

While talking.

At home.

Outside.

And yes, sometimes in a proper workout.

The workout still matters.

But it no longer carries the entire responsibility for movement.

A Small Experiment

For the next three days, don't count calories.

Don't count steps.

Don't create a complicated exercise schedule.

Simply notice.

At the end of the day, ask yourself:

How many times did I get up when I could have remained sitting?

How many times did I walk when I could have stayed where I was?

How many times did I give my body a chance to change position?

You may be surprised.

Not because you suddenly became more active.

But because you finally started noticing the movement that was already part of your life.

Health Should Fit Into Your Day

We often imagine that becoming healthier requires adding more things to an already full life.

Another workout.

Another class.

Another target.

Another tracker.

Another rule.

Sometimes that is necessary.

But not always.

Sometimes the better question is:

What can I change without making my life more complicated?

Drink water during a moment that already exists.

Stand up during a long period of sitting.

Walk while talking when practical.

Stretch when your body asks for it.

Take a few more steps.

Use the stairs when appropriate.

Get up.

Move.

Return to what you were doing.

Again.

And again.

Nothing dramatic.

A Different Way to Measure Movement

Perhaps we need to stop asking only:

“Did I complete my workout?”

And occasionally ask:

“Did I let my body move today?”

Not perfectly.

Not intensely.

Not according to someone else's schedule.

Just regularly.

Because health is not built only in the hour when you exercise.

It is also shaped by what happens in the other twenty-three hours.

A Final Thought

Movement does not always need a beginning and an end.

It can be woven into the day.

A few steps.

A change of position.

A short walk.

A stretch.

A pause.

A proper workout when you have the time and energy.

Then life continues.

That is the shift.

You don't have to find a separate life in which you become healthy.

You can begin making your existing life a little healthier.

Movement doesn't have to be an event you keep waiting for.

It can become a rhythm.

And once it becomes part of the rhythm of everyday life, you no longer have to ask:

"When will I find time to move?"

You simply move.

Chapter 10 - Be a Child Again

The Joyful Path to Weight Loss

When was the last time you moved without wondering whether it was good for you?

Not for your calories.

Not for your steps.

Not for your waistline.

Not because an app told you to.

You simply moved because you felt like it.

A child does this all the time.

A child doesn't need a fitness plan to run across a room.

Doesn't need a trainer to jump.

Doesn't need music to dance.

Doesn't need a mirror to check whether the movement looks right.

And certainly, doesn't need a smartwatch to tell them:

"Congratulations. You have burned 17 calories."

They just move.

And then they move again.

When Did We Become So Serious?

Watch a child for ten minutes.

They may run.

Then sit.

Then jump.

Then lie on the floor.

Then suddenly get up and dance.

They may spin around for absolutely no reason.

They may walk backwards.

They may hop instead of walk.

They may stretch because something feels good.

They may laugh in the middle of all of it.

There is no programme.

No sequence.

No performance.

No concern about whether anyone is watching.

Now watch an adult.

We need the right shoes.

The right clothes.

The right playlist.

The right time.

The right app.

And preferably a photograph proving that we exercised.

Somewhere along the way, movement stopped being something we **enjoyed** and became something we **measured**.

Perhaps that is one thing worth changing.

Not by becoming childish.

But by becoming a little more **childlike**.

A Child Doesn't Ask, “Is This Exercise?”

This is one of the simplest lessons we can borrow.

Suppose you are walking around your living room.

Why must you always walk normally?

For a few seconds, walk like a child.

Take exaggerated steps.

Walk on your toes.

Walk backwards carefully.

Rotate your arms.

Stretch towards the ceiling.

Turn around.

Shake your hands.

Do a silly little dance.

Skip a few steps.

Then continue walking normally.

Nothing dramatic happened.

You didn't complete a workout.

You didn't need to change your clothes.

You simply allowed your body to behave differently for a moment.

And if you feel a little ridiculous doing it...

good.

You may be getting somewhere.

The point isn't to turn your living room into a gym.

The point is to remind yourself:

Your body was designed to move in many ways.

Play Is Not a Waste of Time

Adults often treat play as something that belongs to childhood.

Work is serious.

Exercise is serious.

Health is serious.

Weight loss is very serious.

And somehow, the more serious we become about health, the harder health can begin to feel.

But enjoyable physical activity has an important advantage:

we are more likely to want to do it again.

Research on maintaining physical activity in adults repeatedly identifies enjoyment among the psychological factors that influence long-term participation.

That makes intuitive sense.

You don't need much motivation to repeat something you enjoyed yesterday.

A child doesn't wake up thinking:

"I must find the motivation to play today."

Imagine having that problem.

"Sorry, I can't play today. My motivation levels are only at 43%."

Children simply play.

Perhaps adults could borrow a little of that freedom.

And Then There Is Laughter

Here I want to suggest something slightly unusual.

Try starting your day with laughter.

Not because you have just heard a brilliant joke.

Not because something particularly funny has happened.

Just laugh.

Yes.

Even if it feels artificial at first.

Smile.

Then laugh.

Ha... ha... ha...

It may feel ridiculous.

That's okay.

Do it for a few moments.

And if someone walks past and looks at you as though you have finally lost it...

laugh at them too.

Then invite them to join you.

Imagine beginning the day like that.

Not with an argument.

Not with the news.

Not with the first unpleasant message on your phone.

But with a smile.

And perhaps a completely unnecessary:

“Ha ha ha!”

There is actually more science behind this than you might expect.

Research has looked specifically at laughter and stress responses. A 2023 systematic review and meta-analysis of eight intervention studies involving 315 adults found that laughter interventions were associated with a significant reduction in cortisol compared with control conditions.

Research has also examined **simulated laughter**, rather than only spontaneous laughter. In one randomized controlled trial involving 120 healthy university students, laughter yoga involving simulated laughter was associated with reductions in cortisol over the intervention period, although spontaneous laughter showed a longer-lasting cortisol response.

More recent reviews are also encouraging, although the quality and design of laughter studies vary. A 2026 meta-analysis of 15 randomized controlled trials involving 1,344 adults found reductions in reported stress following laughter interventions, while also noting substantial variation between studies.

So I wouldn't tell you:

"Laugh and you will burn more calories than exercise."

That would be a wonderful sentence.

It just isn't a claim I want to put my name behind without solid evidence.

Instead, I am interested in something much more useful:

Laughter may help change the emotional tone with which you begin the day.

And that matters.

Fake It Until You Make It

There is something interesting about simulated laughter.

At first, you are pretending.

Then something often happens.

The sound becomes easier.

Your face changes.

Your breathing changes.

You may actually start laughing.

And suddenly the artificial laughter isn't quite so artificial anymore.

That is why I like the phrase:

Fake it until you make it.

Not for everything in life.

Certainly not for pretending to be healthy when you are not.

But sometimes the body can lead the mind.

Smile first.

Laugh first.

Move first.

The feeling may follow.

And even when it doesn't, you have still done something wonderfully human:

you gave yourself permission to be playful.

What Children Know That We Forgot

Children are curious about their bodies.

They discover movement.

They experiment.

They don't always move efficiently.

And perhaps that is precisely what makes movement interesting.

Try this sometime.

While walking from one room to another, imagine you are five years old again.

Don't turn it into an exercise routine.

Just experiment.

Can you take three giant steps?

Can you walk like a penguin for five seconds?

Can you stretch your arms as though you are trying to touch both walls?

Can you turn around and walk back?

Can you sway while waiting for the kettle?

Can you dance for ten seconds when your favorite song comes on?

Can you balance briefly on one foot while brushing your teeth—if it is safe for you to do so?

Can you make an ordinary walk slightly less ordinary?

These aren't exercises to tick off.

They are little reminders.

You are allowed to enjoy your body.

When Did We Stop Laughing?

Think about a child laughing.

Sometimes there isn't even an obvious reason.

Something sounds funny.

Someone makes a face.

A friend falls onto a cushion.

Someone says a silly word.

And suddenly...

laughter.

Adults often need a reason.

A joke.

A comedy show.

A party.

A WhatsApp video.

A forwarded meme.

Perhaps we could occasionally remove the requirement.

Laugh because you can.

Smile because you can.

Dance because nobody is grading you.

Move because you are alive.

It doesn't have to be productive.

That may be the most productive part of it.

You Don't Have to Become a Child

This isn't about behaving like a child all day.

You have responsibilities.

Bills.

Work.

Family.

Deadlines.

And unfortunately, someone has to remember where the car keys are.

Growing up is not the problem.

Forgetting how to play is.

The invitation is much simpler:

Bring a little of the child back into the adult.

Be curious.

Be less self-conscious.

Try something silly.

Laugh a little more.

Move without always asking whether it counts.

And occasionally do something simply because it feels good.

Health Doesn't Always Need to Feel Like Work

Perhaps this is the real lesson.

We have spent years making health serious.

We count.

Measure.

Track.

Compare.

Calculate.

Optimise.

And yes, some of that can be useful.

But health is also a lived experience.

It is how you feel when you wake up.

How freely you move.

How easily you laugh.

Whether you enjoy your own body.

Whether movement feels like punishment...

or permission.

Maybe losing weight doesn't require us to become more disciplined every minute of the day.

Maybe sometimes it requires us to become **less serious about the process.**

To move because we feel like moving.

To laugh before we have a reason.

To play without calling it exercise.

To remember the person who once ran simply because there was a place to run.

One Last Thing

Tomorrow morning, before you pick up your phone...

Smile.

Take a breath.

And laugh.

Even if it starts as:

"Ha... ha... ha..."

If it feels silly, let it feel silly.

If someone joins you, laugh together.

And if nobody joins you?

Keep laughing.

Because somewhere inside every serious adult...

there is still a child wondering:

"When did we stop having fun?"

Maybe it's time to answer:

“We didn't. We just forgot.”

And perhaps...

we can remember.



Chapter 11 - Permission to Be Imperfect

How to continue when life gets in the way

Health does not require perfection.

It requires continuity.

And sometimes…

continuity means knowing when to **break the plan.**

The Real Problem

Most people don't fail because they don't know what to do.

They fail because they try to do everything perfectly.

Perfect diet.

Perfect routine.

Perfect timing.

Perfect exercise.

Perfect sleep.

And the moment something goes wrong…

everything feels ruined.

One missed class.

One late night.

One meal outside the plan.

One day when you simply don't feel like doing anything.

And suddenly the mind says:

"Well… today is gone."

That sentence can do more damage than the missed yoga class ever could.

The 2 AM–5 AM Story

You slept at 2 AM.

The alarm rings at 5.

You tell yourself:

"I have to get up.

I'm serious about my health."

So you drag yourself out of bed.

Do your yoga.

Spend the rest of the day exhausted.

Now ask yourself honestly:

Was that a healthy decision?

Or was it simply a **perfect-looking decision**?

Sometimes the healthy choice is to break the plan.

Sleep.

Recover.

Wake up properly.

Continue tomorrow.

Missing one session is not the problem.

Turning every missed session into a battle with yourself is.

Your body also needs recovery.

Health is not a competition between sleep and exercise.

Sometimes the most disciplined thing you can do…

is **not exercise.**

An Old Line We Forgot

There is an old Sanskrit maxim:

अति सर्वत्र वर्जयेत्

Ati sarvatra varjayet.

Avoid excess in everything.

Even something good can become too much.

Even discipline.

Even exercise.

Even dieting.

Even being "serious" about health.

There is wisdom in knowing when enough is enough.

Sometimes the Healthy Choice Is to Break the Plan

This sounds strange in a weight-loss book.

But think about it.

Suppose you have planned your morning yoga.

Then your child is unwell.

Or you had an unusually difficult day at work.

Or you travelled late into the night.

Or you simply need sleep.

Does being healthy mean forcing yourself to complete the original plan at any cost?

Not necessarily.

Sometimes the healthier choice is:

Change the plan.

Not abandon it.

Change it.

That distinction matters.

A plan is supposed to serve your life.

Your life is not supposed to serve the plan.

The "Now Everything Is Ruined" Moment

You miss one workout.

"Okay… today is gone."

You eat something extra.

"Anyway… let me enjoy."

You sleep late.

"I've already messed up."

And suddenly…

one small interruption becomes an entire day of giving up.

Then perhaps tomorrow becomes another restart.

And another.

The problem was never the missed workout.

It was the story you told yourself afterwards.

The Vase We Break Ourselves

Imagine a glass falls from your hand.

It gets a small crack.

Do you pick it up…

and throw it against the wall?

Of course not.

But with our health, we sometimes do exactly that.

One crack…

and we break the whole thing.

One extra meal.

One missed class.

One late night.

One bad decision.

And then:

“Since I've already messed up…”

we continue.

The mistake is small.

The reaction makes it big.

Don't break the vase because it has a crack.

Let Us Remember What You Forget

You missed your yoga session.

Fine.

Now what?

Nothing?

Or something small?

Stand up.

Take a few comfortable, conscious breaths.

Move your arms.

Move your legs.

Stretch.

Shake yourself out.

Walk around the room.

And if you feel like it…

move a little strangely.

Like a child.

No perfect posture.

No sequence.

No instructor.

No clock.

Just move.

One minute.

Two minutes.

Three minutes.

Done.

You didn't complete your original plan.

That's true.

But you didn't give up on yourself either.

Not perfect.

But meaningful.

The day is still yours.

And sometimes that is enough to change the direction of the rest of it.

A Small Smile Moment

If missing one yoga class destroyed your health…

most of us would be in serious trouble.

Thankfully, the body doesn't work like that.

And neither should the mind.

The Social Food Dilemma

Now imagine you are out with friends or family.

Everyone is eating.

Everyone is laughing.

Someone orders your favourite dish.

And you are sitting there thinking:

“I'm on a diet.”

So you resist.

You calculate.

You negotiate with yourself.

You feel guilty before you've even eaten anything.

Now ask yourself:

What is heavier?

The food?

Or the mental burden you have placed around it?

There is a place for thoughtful food choices.

Of course.

But health should not make you incapable of sitting at a table with people you love.

Sometimes you can participate.

Enjoy the meal.

Eat consciously.

Know that tomorrow still exists.

You don't need to turn one social meal into either a victory or a failure.

It was simply…

one meal.

We Are Not Meant to Be Perfect

We are meant to live.

To enjoy.

To participate.

To sit with people.

To laugh.

To travel.

To celebrate.

To have birthdays.

To eat with friends.

To sometimes sleep late.

To sometimes change our plans.

Health has to survive all of that.

If your health routine works only on your best days…

it isn't really a life routine.

It is a performance.

The real test is what happens on an ordinary, messy Tuesday.

The Broken Day Myth

One wrong meal.

One missed workout.

One late night.

One lazy morning.

That's it.

That is all it is.

Not a failed day.

Just…

one moment.

Don't give one moment the power to define the whole day.

And don't give one day the power to define you.

The Real Skill

We often think the most important health skill is discipline.

Maybe it isn't.

Maybe the real skill is:

How quickly do you come back?

Not with punishment.

Not with guilt.

Not with an extreme detox.

Not with a six-day workout plan.

Just…

come back.

Eat normally at the next meal.

Sleep properly that night.

Move when you can.

Attend the next class.

Drink some water.

Take a breath.

Continue.

That's it.

Sometimes, Come Back Differently

There is another lesson here.

Coming back doesn't always mean returning to the original plan.

Sometimes the original plan itself needs changing.

If waking at 5 AM after sleeping at 2 AM repeatedly leaves you exhausted…

perhaps the routine needs reconsideration.

If a one-hour workout is so demanding that you avoid it for a week…

perhaps a shorter session is better.

If a diet is so restrictive that one social dinner feels like a disaster…

perhaps it is too rigid.

If your health plan constantly makes you feel guilty…

perhaps the plan needs to become kinder.

Recovery is not always returning to the old plan.

Sometimes it means creating a better one.

Permission to Be Imperfect

Give yourself permission.

To miss a day.

To change a plan.

To eat something you didn't plan.

To sleep instead of exercising when your body genuinely needs rest.

To laugh with friends.

To have an imperfect day.

And then…

to continue.

Because health is not built by a person who never slips.

It is built by a person who doesn't turn every slip into a fall.

You don't have to win every day.

You just have to avoid declaring the day lost.

The day is still yours.

And tomorrow…

you don't have to start again.

You simply continue.

Chapter 12 - Weight Is Not the Goal - Health Is

Restore the system, and the body finds its balance

Weight is visible.

Health is not.

And perhaps that is where much of our confusion begins.

We can see a number on a weighing scale.

We cannot see good sleep.

We cannot see comfortable digestion.

We cannot see steady energy.

We cannot see how easily someone climbs stairs, bends down, plays with a child, or wakes up feeling refreshed.

Yet somehow…

we let one number tell us whether we are healthy.

A Simple Question

Why do you want to lose weight?

Most people will say:

“To look better.”

“To feel lighter.”

“To be healthier.”

All perfectly understandable.

But slowly…

something can change.

Health becomes secondary.

Weight becomes the goal.

And once weight becomes the only goal, the scale starts controlling the mood.

It goes down—

Good day.

It doesn't—

Bad day.

You feel successful.

Or unsuccessful.

Confident.

Or disappointed.

All because of one number.

But your body is much bigger than that number.

The Scale Cannot See the Whole Story

Imagine two people weighing exactly the same.

One sleeps well.

Has good energy.

Moves comfortably.

Eats without constant guilt.

Enjoys life.

The other is exhausted.

Stressed.

Sleeps poorly.

Feels uncomfortable in the body.

Which one is healthier?

The weighing scale cannot answer that.

It only tells you your relationship with gravity.

It doesn't tell you how you are living.

That doesn't mean weight is unimportant.

It can be an important health measure.

But it is **one measure**.

Not the whole story.

There Is More Than One Kind of Progress

Instead of asking only:

"How much weight did I lose?"

also ask:

Did I sleep better?

Do I have more energy?

Am I moving more easily?

Is my digestion more comfortable?

Am I less breathless?

Am I eating with less guilt?

Am I enjoying food again?

Am I becoming stronger?

Am I more consistent?

Do I feel better in my own body?

These may not show up on the weighing scale.

But they are still progress.

And sometimes…

they are the progress that matters most.

The Body Is Always Trying to Find Balance

There is a simple idea in modern science called **homeostasis**.

You don't need to remember the word.

Just remember the idea.

Your body is constantly adjusting.

Temperature.

Fluids.

Energy.

Many internal processes.

It is always trying to keep you going.

Your body is not sitting inside you waiting for an opportunity to make your life difficult.

It is responding to what is happening around it.

That is why extreme approaches can be so difficult to maintain.

You may force the number down.

But your hunger may increase.

Your energy may fall.

Your cravings may become stronger.

And eventually…

the old pattern returns.

This is not always a failure of discipline.

Sometimes the approach itself is asking too much.

An Old Understanding

Ayurveda looked at the body through another beautiful idea:

balance.

One of its important concepts is **Agni**—the digestive fire.

We have already spoken about Agni earlier in this book.

Here, we need only remember the bigger idea.

When the body's processes are supported, Ayurveda describes the person as being in a better state of balance.

When they are disturbed, heaviness, discomfort and accumulation can follow.

It gives us a different question.

Instead of asking only:

"How do I get rid of this weight?"

perhaps ask:

"How do I take better care of the person carrying this weight?"

That is a very different starting point.

The Smoke and the Fire

Imagine there is smoke in a room.

You open the windows.

You switch on a fan.

You try to push the smoke outside.

But the smoke keeps coming.

Why?

Because the fire is still burning.

You can keep fighting the smoke.

Or you can look for the fire.

Weight can sometimes feel like the smoke.

We become obsessed with removing what we can see.

The number.

The inches.

The appearance.

But the things happening underneath may deserve attention too:

Sleep.

Food.

Movement.

Stress.

Digestion.

Daily routine.

Habits.

Environment.

The answer is not to blame the weight.

And it is not to blame yourself.

It is to look deeper.

The Body Is Not Your Enemy

This may be one of the most important shifts in this entire book.

Your body is not your enemy.

It is not trying to embarrass you.

It is not trying to defeat your diet.

It is not keeping extra weight simply to annoy you.

Your body is responding to your life.

Sometimes that response may not be what you want.

But fighting the body harder is not always the answer.

Understanding it is a better place to begin.

When the Number Doesn't Move

Here is something that can be surprisingly difficult.

You have been eating better.

You have been moving.

You are sleeping better.

You feel lighter.

Your clothes fit differently.

You have more energy.

Then you step on the scale.

Nothing.

Or perhaps the number has even gone up.

And suddenly…

all the good things disappear from your mind.

This is where the scale can become dangerous—not because weighing yourself is wrong, but because **one measurement can become the judge of your entire effort.**

Don't let it.

Look at the whole picture.

The scale is information.

It is not your report card.

What Are You Really Trying to Build?

Perhaps the real goal is not:

“I want to become lighter.”

Perhaps it is:

“I want to become healthier.”

Healthier enough to wake up with energy.

Healthy enough to move without fear.

Healthy enough to enjoy food without constantly fighting it.

Healthy enough to sleep well.

Healthy enough to laugh.

Healthy enough to travel.

Healthy enough to climb stairs.

Healthy enough to play.

Healthy enough to grow older without feeling that your body has become a burden.

And yes…

perhaps healthier enough for your weight to move in a better direction too.

But now weight has become **part of the journey**, not the entire destination.

A Small Insight

When weight becomes the only goal, every day becomes a test.

But when health becomes the goal, there are many ways to win.

You slept well.

That's a win.

You went for a walk.

That's a win.

You stopped eating when you were comfortably satisfied.

That's a win.

You chose water instead of another sugary drink.

That's a win.

You laughed with your family.

That's a win.

You missed your yoga class…

but later moved for ten minutes instead of doing nothing.

That's a win too.

These things may look small.

But they are building something bigger.

A healthier person.

A Better Question

So perhaps we should stop asking only:

"How much weight have I lost?"

And start asking:

"What kind of person am I becoming?"

Someone who is constantly fighting food?

Or someone who understands it?

Someone who punishes the body?

Or someone who cares for it?

Someone who waits for Monday?

Or someone who knows how to continue on an ordinary Tuesday?

Someone obsessed with the scale?

Or someone who notices the whole body?

That is a much more interesting journey.

The Real Goal

You need to become a person whose body does not need to hold extra weight.

Not through punishment.

Not through starvation.

Not through endless restarting.

But by gradually creating a life that supports health.

Sleep.

Food.

Movement.

Digestion.

Stress.

Rest.

Relationships.

Joy.

Consistency.

The things we have explored throughout this book are not separate tricks.

They are pieces of the same picture.

And the picture is bigger than weight.

One Last Look at the Scale

Keep the scale if it helps you.

Use it as information.

But don't hand it the authority to decide how you feel about yourself.

A number can change overnight.

Your health is a much bigger story.

So weigh yourself if you want.

Measure your waist if it is useful.

Track your progress if that motivates you.

But also notice the things no measuring tape can capture.

How you feel when you wake up.

How you breathe.

How you move.

How you eat.

How you sleep.

How you live.

Because perhaps the most important transformation is not:

"I lost 10 kilos."

It is:

"I became healthier."

And when health becomes the goal…

weight finally gets its proper place.

Not the destination.

Just one part of the journey.

Chapter 13 - If You Have a Deadline

Accelerate gently without disturbing the system

Sometimes, you want faster results.

A wedding is coming.

A holiday.

A reunion.

A photograph.

A special occasion.

And suddenly you look at yourself and think:

"I have to do something."

That's perfectly human.

There is nothing wrong with wanting to look a little lighter, feel less bloated, or fit more comfortably into your clothes.

The problem begins when the deadline makes you desperate.

You stop eating.

You exercise for two hours.

You sleep less.

You try a juice.

Then a powder.

Then some miracle drink someone recommended.

Then another one.

Because when the date is getting closer…

everything starts looking like a solution.

But there is a better way.

You Can Move Faster

You can.

Sometimes a little acceleration is useful.

But remember:

You can move faster without losing balance.

Think of driving a car.

You can press the accelerator.

But you still need the steering wheel.

You still need the brakes.

And you still need to know where you are going.

The same is true of your body.

A short period of greater discipline can help.

But don't turn it into punishment.

Start With What Makes You Feel Heavy

When time is short, don't start by adding ten new things.

Look first at what you can simplify.

Late-night eating.

Constant snacking.

Sugary drinks.

Deep-fried food.

Large dinners.

Highly processed food.

Eating simply because everyone else is eating.

And perhaps…

eating when you are not even hungry.

You may be surprised by how much better you feel simply by stopping some of these.

The scale may change.

Your waist may feel different.

Your face may look less puffy.

Your digestion may feel better.

Your energy may improve.

Not every visible change is fat loss.

Some may come from less bloating, changes in water retention, or simply having less food in the digestive system.

But if you feel lighter…

that's still a good beginning.

Give Your Body Some Space

There is another simple thing you can try.

Give yourself a little more space between meals.

If you normally eat dinner late at night and breakfast very early in the morning, perhaps you can gently extend that gap.

Not by starving yourself.

Not by forcing hunger.

Simply ask:

"Am I actually hungry?"

Sometimes the answer is no.

You were following the clock.

Or habit.

Or boredom.

Or simply responding to the sight of food.

A little space can create a little awareness.

And awareness is often more useful than another rule.

Keep Food Simple

When you have a deadline, this is not the time to experiment with a complicated diet.

Keep food familiar.

Fresh.

Simple.

Comfortable.

A bowl of dal.

Vegetables.

Rice.

Roti.

Moong dal khichdi.

Fruit when it suits you.

A simple meal can sometimes do more for you than a complicated diet plan you follow for three days and abandon on the fourth.

Khichdi has a special place in traditional Indian health practices.

Rice and dal.

A little seasoning.

Simple cooking.

Easy to understand.

Easy to prepare.

Easy to eat.

Sometimes the body does not need another superfood.

It needs a little simplicity.

What About Triphala?

We have already spoken about digestion and traditional approaches to food.

Triphala has been used traditionally in Ayurveda to support digestion and elimination. It is also commonly included in traditional approaches for managing excess weight.

For some people, it becomes part of a simple night-time routine, taken after the evening meal or before sleep.

Again, it doesn't need to become another complicated ritual.

The point is not to collect remedies.

If you are taking medicines or have a health condition, it is sensible to discuss its use with your doctor or a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner.

Your Morning Can Also Change

What happens in the first few minutes after you wake up?

Phone.

Messages.

News.

Social media.

Another ten minutes disappears.

Instead, begin gently.

Drink some water.

Sit quietly.

Move your body.

Take a few comfortable breaths.

Perhaps do a few simple yoga movements.

You don't need a dramatic morning routine.

You simply need to tell your body:

"Good morning. I haven't forgotten you."

And Then There Are the Traditional Practices

Yoga has always had more than postures and breathing exercises.

Traditional yoga also includes **Shatkarma** — cleansing practices.

Among them are **Kunjal**, also called Gajakarama, and **Shankh Prakshalana**, also known as Varisara.

These are powerful practices.

They are not ordinary morning exercises.

They are traditional cleansing kriyas and should be learnt properly from an experienced teacher who has practical knowledge of them and can supervise the practice.

They may not be suitable for everyone.

If you have a health condition, take medication, are pregnant, or have any particular medical concern, discuss them with your doctor before attempting them.

There is nothing embarrassing about asking.

Wisdom is knowing when to learn from someone else.

Kunjal

Kunjal involves drinking warm water and then bringing it back up as part of the traditional cleansing process.

It sounds simple.

It isn't something to casually try because you watched a video.

The traditional instructions are specific.

The practice has its own preparation and method.

And the old texts themselves emphasise proper guidance and caution for people with certain health conditions.

So if you want to learn Kunjal…

learn it properly.

A powerful practice deserves a knowledgeable teacher.

Shankh Prakshalana

Shankh Prakshalana is even more intensive.

The traditional practice uses warm saline water and a sequence of movements that helps the water pass through the digestive tract.

When you first hear about it, it can sound almost funny.

“That's all?

I just drink water and do a few movements?”

Try it.

After a few glasses, your body may have a very different opinion.

And after several more…

you may discover that the real challenge is not simply the water.

It is the conversation between your mind and your body.

One of my teachers once explained it beautifully.

**“I am doing this for you.

Please accept it.

Work with me.”**

There is something profound about that.

You are not simply forcing the body.

You are learning to cooperate with it.

I have practised Shankh Prakshalana myself several times.

And that experience changed the way I look at the practice.

At first, the mind says:

“Of course I can do this.”

Then the body says:

“Are you sure?”

And somewhere along the way, you discover that determination is not enough.

You have to develop communication between the mind and the body.

That is one of the reasons I find these kriyas so fascinating.

They are physical.

But they demand mental participation too.

Cleansing Is Not the Same as Starving

Traditional yoga and naturopathy have long placed importance on cleansing and elimination.

The underlying idea is simple:

When unnecessary accumulation builds up…

remove what does not belong.

Give the system some rest.

Support digestion.

Support elimination.

Create lightness.

This is very different from starving yourself.

Starvation says:

"Give the body less."

Cleansing, in the traditional sense, says:

"Help the body clear what it does not need."

That distinction matters.

But Don't Forget What Comes After

With powerful cleansing practices, the practice itself is only one part of the process.

Traditional instructions for Shankh Prakshalana include considerable attention to what happens afterward.

Food is kept very simple.

The digestive system is given time.

Certain foods are avoided.

The body is allowed to settle.

You cannot spend hours asking your body to undergo an intensive process…

and then immediately celebrate with a heavy meal.

That would be like cleaning your house…

and throwing the garbage back inside.

The lesson is bigger than Shankh Prakshalana.

What you do after an intervention matters too.

Kapalbhati

Kapalbhati is another traditional yogic practice that has attracted attention in research on metabolic health.

Some studies have reported improvements in BMI and other metabolic measures among people practising it regularly.

It is an interesting example of an old yogic practice being explored through modern research.

For someone who already practises Kapalbhati as part of yoga, it can be another part of a broader approach to health and weight management.

The important word is:

broader.

Your health is never resting on one kriya.

Warmth, Digestion and Lightness

We have already explored **Agni — the digestive fire** earlier in the book.

Here, there is no need to repeat the whole explanation.

For a short period before an important event, simply return to the basics:

Warm food.

Warm water.

Simple meals.

Appropriate meal timing.

Less unnecessary eating.

These are not glamorous ideas.

But health rarely needs to be glamorous.

Sometimes it needs to be sensible.

Don't Turn a Deadline Into a Crisis

When the deadline gets close, there is a temptation to think:

"I have to do everything."

No.

You don't suddenly need:

three workouts,

a juice cleanse,

a fasting plan,

five supplements,

a new diet,

and a morning routine that requires an alarm at 4:30 a.m.

Please don't do that.

You are trying to feel better.

Not win an award for suffering.

Sometimes the Plan Has to Bend

Imagine you planned to exercise every morning.

One morning you slept badly.

You have a long day ahead.

Your body feels exhausted.

The plan says:

"Exercise."

Your body says:

“Please sleep.”

You already know the lesson from the previous chapter.

Sometimes the healthier choice is to adjust the plan.

Not because you are lazy.

Because the plan exists for the body.

The body does not exist for the plan.

You can return when you are ready.

Speed Is Not the Same as Success

A crash diet can make the scale move quickly.

So can dehydration.

So can eating almost nothing.

But if you become exhausted, miserable and obsessed with food…

what exactly have you achieved?

You have reached the number.

But lost the person.

That is not our goal.

The goal is to become healthier while becoming lighter.

Not lighter at any cost.

One Last Thought About Deadlines

Perhaps the deadline is useful.

It makes you pay attention.

For a few days, you notice:

What you eat.

When you eat.

How much you eat.

How you sleep.

How much you move.

How you feel.

And perhaps you discover something wonderful.

You didn't need a miracle.

You simply needed to stop doing a few things that were making you feel worse.

That is a much more useful discovery.

Because the wedding will pass.

The photograph will pass.

The holiday will pass.

The reunion will pass.

But your body stays with you.

So, If You Really Need to Accelerate…

Accelerate gently.

Sleep.

Eat simply.

Move.

Hydrate.

Reduce unnecessary eating.

Support your normal routines.

Use traditional practices thoughtfully.

Learn powerful kriyas from people who know them.

Give the body proper aftercare.

And most importantly…

don't let the deadline make you stupid.

Your body has to live with whatever you decide today.

The Real Shortcut

The real shortcut isn't finding something that makes weight disappear quickly.

It is learning how to stop creating the same problem again.

Because if you lose five kilos for the wedding…

and gain them back after the wedding…

you didn't really find a solution.

You found a temporary escape.

The better goal is:

Move faster when you need to.

Return to balance when you don't.

And then keep going.

Because the deadline will end.

The celebration will end.

The photographs will end.

But your health journey continues.

You don't need to arrive perfectly.

You just need to keep moving in the right direction.

Chapter 14 - Helping Children Grow Strong in an Unhealthy World

Building healthy habits before weight becomes the problem

This Is Not About Weight

When it comes to children…

we must be very clear.

This is not about weight loss.

It is about:

Growth.

Strength.

Confidence.

And a healthy relationship with life.

A growing child needs nourishment.

Movement.

Sleep.

Play.

Love.

And the freedom to grow without constantly wondering whether their body is "right" or "wrong."

We should be careful about turning a child into a weight-loss project.

The goal is not to make children smaller.

The goal is to help them grow stronger.

The Greatest Gift May Be a Childhood

There was a time when childhood meant:

Scraped knees.

Muddy shoes.

Bicycles.

Climbing trees.

Hide-and-seek.

Cricket until someone shouted,

"Come home!"

Kabaddi.

Kho-kho.

Hopscotch.

Flying kites.

Running for no particular reason.

Today, childhood can look very different.

Online classes.

Tuition.

Mobile games.

Television.

Social media.

Food delivery.

Air-conditioned rooms.

And a phone that is never very far away.

Children haven't suddenly become lazy.

Their world has changed.

Yesterday, movement happened because life happened outside.

Today, much of life can happen without leaving the chair.

And that changes things.

Children Don't Need More Discipline

Tell a child:

“Do your exercise.”

You may get a face that says:

“Why?”

Tell the same child:

“Come, let's play.”

Suddenly…

they are ready.

That difference matters.

Children don't necessarily need an exercise programme.

They need opportunities to move.

Run.

Jump.

Climb.

Dance.

Cycle.

Skip.

Play catch.

Play hide-and-seek.

Race each other.

Kick a ball.

Make up their own games.

Sometimes even do something completely silly.

Because for a child, movement doesn't have to be called exercise.

It can simply be play.

And that is something worth protecting.

Don't Take the Playground Away

A ball lying in the corner may become a game.

A skipping rope may become a challenge.

A bicycle may become an adventure.

A park nearby may become the evening plan.

Children are more likely to use what is easy to see and easy to reach.

The same is true of food.

If the kitchen makes fresh, simple food easy to find…

that becomes normal.

If water is always available…

that becomes normal.

If every cupboard is full of packaged snacks…

those become normal too.

We don't have to turn the home into a laboratory.

Just make healthier choices easier.

The environment teaches quietly.

Do It Together

This may be one of the most important things a parent can do.

Go for a walk.

Cycle together.

Play badminton.

Throw a ball.

Dance in the living room.

Go to the park.

Take the stairs.

Play a silly game.

It doesn't have to look like fitness.

And it certainly doesn't need to be perfect.

Children watch.

If movement is normal in the family…

they see movement as normal.

Health is not only taught through instructions.

It is absorbed through everyday life.

Don't Ban Everything

You don't have to declare war on chocolate.

You don't have to panic when your child eats pizza.

You don't have to say:

“That food is bad.”

And you don't have to make every treat forbidden.

Instead…

change what is normal at home.

Keep better choices easy to find.

Keep whole fruits around.

Prepare simple homemade snacks.

Offer fresh meals.

Let treats remain treats.

Not everyday food.

Not a reward.

Not a punishment.

Not something that needs a dramatic announcement.

Food should not become a battlefield.

Healthy Can Be Tasty

Children don't usually ask:

“Is this nutritionally optimal?”

They ask:

“Does it taste good?”

Fair enough.

We were children once too.

So make good food enjoyable.

Whole fruits.

Seasonal fruits.

Homemade snacks.

Simple Indian meals.

Freshly prepared food.

Different colours.

Different textures.

Food that looks and smells inviting.

We don't need to convince a child that spinach is a superfood.

We can simply make spinach taste good.

That may work better.

No Need for Strict Diets

Children are growing.

They need nourishment.

They need enough food.

They need variety.

They need the freedom to develop normally.

So the goal should not be:

Eat less.

It should be:

Eat better.

And even that doesn't need to become an obsession.

One meal will not make a child unhealthy.

One birthday party will not undo a healthy lifestyle.

One ice cream will not create a problem.

Just as one salad will not create health.

We are building a pattern, not judging a meal.

Say “Grow Strong” More Than “Don't Get Fat”

There is a big difference between these two messages:

“Don't eat that. You'll get fat.”

and:

“Let's eat this. It will help you grow strong.”

One creates fear.

The other creates a direction.

Children need to understand that food, movement and sleep are not punishments for having the “wrong” body.

They are ways of taking care of the body they already have.

And this becomes especially important as children become conscious of appearance.

A child should not grow up believing:

“My body is a problem I have to solve.”

They should learn:

“My body is something I can take care of.”

Sometimes the Child Is Not Hungry

A child comes home and reaches for a packet of chips.

Again.

The first reaction may be:

“Don't eat that.”

But sometimes there is another question worth asking.

“How was your day?”

Maybe the child did badly in a test.

Maybe a classmate made fun of them.

Maybe they are struggling to keep up.

Maybe they feel different from everyone else.

Maybe someone said something about their appearance.

Maybe they were bullied.

Maybe they are under pressure.

Maybe they simply had a terrible day.

Sometimes food becomes comfort.

Not because the child is greedy.

Because food is available.

Immediate.

Familiar.

Comforting.

So if we only remove the food…

we may remove the comfort without understanding the problem.

Don't only change what is in the child's hand.

Try to understand what is in the child's heart.

Ask.

Listen.

Sit with them.

Talk.

Find out what is happening.

Sometimes the child doesn't need another rule.

Sometimes the child needs someone to listen.

And if a child seems persistently distressed, withdrawn, unusually anxious, bullied, or increasingly preoccupied with food or appearance, it is worth seeking appropriate professional help rather than trying to solve everything through food rules.

Before You Ask What They Ate…

Ask:

"How was your day?"

Not every day.

Not like an interrogation.

Just sometimes.

Because a child may say:

"Fine."

And then…

five minutes later…

tell you the entire story.

If you give them the space.

A healthy home is not only about healthy food.

It is also about feeling safe enough to talk.

The Family Meal

A family meal can do something a food chart cannot.

It brings people together.

Sit down.

Eat.

Talk.

Laugh.

Listen.

Keep the phones away when possible.

The food doesn't have to be fancy.

Dal and roti can be a family meal.

Khichdi can be a family meal.

Vegetables and rice can be a family meal.

What matters is that food is not always eaten alone, in front of a screen, or while rushing from one activity to another.

Sometimes the healthiest thing on the table is simply…

conversation.

Screens and Sleep

Screens are not evil.

Technology is not evil.

The problem is what they replace.

A little more screen time can quietly mean:

Less outdoor play.

Less conversation.

Less movement.

Less sleep.

And late-night scrolling is not exactly what a growing child needs.

Sometimes the simplest solution is also the hardest:

Parents put their phones away too.

Because telling a child,

"Go to sleep. No more screens."

while sitting beside them watching a phone…

is a difficult lesson to sell.

Children notice.

The Mirror Effect

Children watch how we talk about our own bodies.

If a parent stands in front of the mirror and says:

"I'm getting fat."

or constantly talks about dieting…

the child hears it.

If a parent is frightened of food…

the child notices.

If every meal becomes a discussion about calories, weight and appearance…

the child learns that the body is something to worry about.

But if a parent moves with ease…

eats without fear…

enjoys food…

takes care of health…

and doesn't constantly criticise their own body…

the child learns something very different.

"My body is worth caring for.

I don't have to hate it to take care of it."

That may be one of the most valuable lessons a parent can give.

Parents Don't Have to Be Perfect

This is important too.

We don't need a perfect home.

Parents will order pizza.

Children will eat sweets.

Someone will skip a walk.

Someone will spend too long on the phone.

Someone will sleep late.

That is life.

We are not trying to create perfect children.

Or perfect parents.

We are creating a healthier direction.

If the family gets off track…

come back.

If yesterday was unhealthy…

today can be different.

Health is built from patterns, not perfection.

A Small Change in the Question

Instead of asking:

"How do I make my child lose weight?"

perhaps ask:

"How do I create a home where healthy living becomes normal?"

That changes everything.

Maybe the answer is:

A bicycle near the door.

Fruit on the table.

Water within reach.

A family walk after dinner.

An evening at the park.

A game instead of another hour of television.

A family meal.

An earlier bedtime.

A conversation.

A little less packaged food.

A little more laughter.

None of these sounds dramatic.

That's the point.

We Need to Raise Movers, Not Dieters

Perhaps the biggest mistake we can make is teaching children that health begins with controlling their weight.

Instead…

teach them to enjoy movement.

Teach them to enjoy real food.

Teach them to sleep.

Teach them to laugh.

Teach them to explore.

Teach them to respect their bodies.

Teach them that health is something they **live**, not something they have to constantly measure.

A child who grows up seeing movement as part of life may not need to be chased around with a fitness plan later.

And a child who grows up seeing food as nourishment rather than a source of guilt may develop a very different relationship with it.

Change the Environment, Not the Child

We often look at a child and think:

"Something about the child needs to change."

Sometimes…

the environment needs to change first.

Change what is easily available.

Change what the family does together.

Change what is considered normal.

Change how we talk about bodies.

Change how we respond to emotions.

Change how much time children have to simply…

be children.

And then watch what happens.

A Final Thought

The greatest gift we can give our children isn't a gym membership.

It is a childhood.

Give them back the bicycle.

Give them back the playground.

Give them family meals.

Give them sunshine.

Give them laughter.

Give them enough sleep.

Give them friends.

Give them the freedom to run without counting steps.

Let them climb.

Let them dance.

Let them get a little muddy.

Let them play until they forget that they were supposed to be exercising.

Because healthy children are not created by constantly telling them to be healthy.

They are created by building a world around them where **running, laughing, eating well, sleeping, playing, exploring and being loved are simply part of everyday life.**

Don't make the child carry the burden of fixing the lifestyle.

Build a lifestyle in which the child can grow strong.



Chapter 15 - Strong and Steady: Health in the Later Years

Staying active, capable, and connected as the body changes

The Biggest Mistake We Make

As people grow older…

we start telling them:

"Rest."

"Don't do this."

"Don't go to the kitchen."

"Don't take the stairs."

"Let me do it."

It usually comes from love.

We want to protect them.

But sometimes, in protecting a person from movement, we slowly take something very important away from them:

their independence.

The body is not meant to stop simply because we have grown older.

Rest is important.

But so is living.

Rest Is Important. But So Is Living

If an older person enjoys cooking…

let them cook.

If they enjoy gardening…

let them garden.

If they want to walk to the market…

let them walk, if it is safe.

If they want to clean a small part of the house…

let them.

If they enjoy climbing a few stairs…

don't automatically say, “No, no, you are old now.”

These are not just tasks.

They are life.

Every time we do something for an older person that they can safely do for themselves, we may be making life easier for them today…

but a little harder tomorrow.

The goal is not to make an older person do everything.

The goal is to help them **keep doing what they can.**

The Real Risk Is Not Movement

The real risk is often **stopping movement completely.**

Once movement reduces…

strength begins to reduce.

Balance may reduce.

Confidence may reduce.

Everyday activities become harder.

And then the person moves even less.

It can become a quiet cycle:

Less movement → less strength → less confidence → even less movement.

Sometimes the biggest problem after a fall is not the fall itself.

It is the fear that comes afterwards.

"What if I fall again?"

So the person stops walking.

Stops going outside.

Avoids stairs.

Sits more.

And slowly, the world becomes smaller.

We need to break that cycle.

Gently.

Safely.

Early.

Keep Doing What You Can

No matter the age…

do something.

Anything that your body comfortably allows.

Walk a little.

Stand a little more.

Move your hands.

Move your shoulders.

Stretch gently.

Get up from the chair.

Walk around the room.

Do a few movements while watching television.

You don't have to do everything at once.

Even five or ten small moments of movement spread through the day can make a difference.

The goal is not a perfect workout.

The goal is to keep the body participating in life.

You Don't Need to Get Down on the Floor

For some people, getting down on the floor becomes difficult.

Then don't.

Use a chair.

Use the bed.

Use the wall for support.

Movement can happen almost anywhere.

Arm raises.

Gentle leg movements.

Shoulder movements.

Ankle movements.

Gentle twists.

Light stretches.

Two or three minutes at a time.

Then again later.

There is no prize for doing everything in one session.

Small movement, repeated often, is still movement.

Strength Becomes More Important

There is something we often forget as we grow older.

Strength matters.

Walking is wonderful.

Yoga is wonderful.

Breathing practices are wonderful.

But the body also needs resistance.

Because strength is what helps you do ordinary things.

Get up from a chair.

Climb the stairs.

Carry groceries.

Lift a small bag.

Open a door.

Pick something up.

Recover when you lose your balance.

Play with your grandchildren.

And most importantly…

remain independent.

A resistance band can help.

A pair of light dumbbells.

A couple of water bottles.

Even your own body weight.

Simple resistance, done regularly, tells the body:

"Stay strong. I still need you."

Strength training after 60 is not about becoming a bodybuilder.

It is about making everyday life easier.

Walking, Yoga and Strength Work Together

Think of them as different friends.

Walking helps keep you moving and supports everyday endurance.

Yoga helps with mobility, flexibility, balance, breathing and awareness.

Strength work helps preserve the strength needed for everyday activities.

You don't have to choose one and reject the others.

They complement each other.

A little walking.

A little yoga.

A little strength work.

And plenty of ordinary movement.

That is a much better picture of healthy ageing than spending one hour exercising and then sitting for the rest of the day.

Knees and Back Need Care

For many people, the knees and back become the first places where movement starts becoming difficult.

So give them attention.

Gently.

Regularly.

But don't think of pain as something you simply have to ignore.

If your knees hurt…

change how you move.

Sit down.

Move your arms.

Try gentle movements that are comfortable.

If walking is difficult…

perhaps some movement can be done while sitting.

If one movement is uncomfortable…

try another.

And if pain is persistent, severe, or unusual, get it properly assessed.

Adapting movement is not giving up.

It is being intelligent about movement.

Breath Is Always Available

There may be days when the body does not want to cooperate.

That is when the breath becomes a beautiful tool.

Sit comfortably.

Relax the shoulders.

Breathe slowly.

Breathe deeply, without forcing.

Let the breath become smooth.

Even when the legs are tired…

the breath can still move.

Even when walking is difficult…

you can still breathe consciously.

Even while sitting quietly…

you can still connect with your body.

Sometimes health is not about doing more.

Sometimes it is about becoming more aware of what is already happening inside you.

Food Should Become Simpler

As we grow older, many people find that digestion changes.

So why make food complicated?

Simple.

Warm.

Fresh.

Easy to digest.

Comforting.

Traditional foods that suit the person can have a valuable place here.

There is no need to chase complicated diets.

And there is no need to fear food.

Eat to support the changing body, not to punish it.

The Hidden Problem: Isolation

There is another kind of inactivity that we don't talk about enough.

Emotional inactivity.

Less movement.

Less conversation.

Less going out.

Less involvement.

Less laughter.

Less responsibility.

And slowly…

interest in life can begin to shrink.

An older person may be physically sitting in the same room…

but emotionally, they may be becoming more and more disconnected.

That is why connection is not a luxury.

It is part of healthy ageing.

Stay Connected

Talk.

Meet people.

Laugh.

Have a meal together.

Take a short walk with someone.

Call an old friend.

Play with the grandchildren.

Attend a family function.

Sit in the park.

Join a group.

Teach someone something you know.

Ask for their opinion.

Let them make decisions.

Let them feel useful.

Sometimes the best health intervention is simply:

“Come, let's go for a walk.”

Not every walk needs to be about exercise.

Sometimes it is just about having someone beside you.

Keep the Mind Involved

The body needs movement.

The mind needs engagement.

Give an older person small responsibilities.

Let them decide what to cook.

Let them manage something at home.

Play cards.

Solve puzzles.

Read.

Write.

Listen to music.

Learn something new.

Teach a grandchild an old game.

Tell stories.

Make decisions.

Keep learning.

The message should never be:

“You are old. Let us do everything for you.”

Instead:

“You are still part of this. What would you like to do?”

That one question can change the feeling of a day.

Environment Matters

As we grow older, small things around us become more important.

A slippery floor.

A loose rug.

Poor lighting.

Unstable footwear.

Clutter in a walking path.

A bathroom without support.

These may look like small things.

But small precautions can prevent big problems.

Make the home easier to move around in.

Good light.

Clear pathways.

Non-slippery surfaces.

Stable footwear.

Support where genuinely needed.

Safety should not mean putting the person in a chair all day.

Safety should make movement easier.

Growing Older Is Not the Same as Stopping

There is a difference between:

"I cannot do this anymore."

and

"I cannot do this in the same way anymore."

The second sentence leaves the door open.

Perhaps you cannot walk as far.

Walk a shorter distance.

Perhaps you cannot get down to the floor.

Use a chair.

Perhaps you cannot lift the same weight.

Use a lighter one.

Perhaps your knees need more care.

Change the movement.

Perhaps you need more rest between activities.

Take it.

Adaptation is not defeat.

It is wisdom.

A Small Smile Moment

We spend so much time worrying about ageing.

Perhaps we should also spend some time enjoying it.

Laugh with your friends.

Dance in the living room if you feel like it.

Play with your grandchildren.

Tell the same old story again.

And if someone says,

"You have told us this story before…"

you can always say,

"Yes. And you will probably hear it again."

Growing old is natural.

Becoming inactive is not something we have to accept simply because the calendar says so.

A Simple Question

What if healthy ageing was not about trying to remain young?

What if it was simply about remaining capable?

Capable of getting out of bed.

Capable of walking to the kitchen.

Capable of climbing a few stairs.

Capable of carrying your own bag.

Capable of going out.

Capable of meeting people.

Capable of making your own choices.

Capable of playing with your grandchildren.

Capable of saying:

"I can still do it."

That is a very different definition of fitness.

A Final Thought

Health in later years is not about doing more.

It is about **not stopping unnecessarily.**

Move a little.

Many times.

Build strength.

Protect your balance.

Adapt when the body changes.

Breathe.

Eat simply.

Stay connected.

Keep your mind involved.

And let the people around you help when you truly need help…

but not take away everything you can still do for yourself.

Because the goal of healthy ageing is not to look young.

It is to remain capable of living your own life.

Growing older is inevitable.

Growing wiser is a choice.

Growing weaker may happen.

But we can work every day to remain **strong, steady and involved.**

And perhaps that is what healthy ageing really means:

Not adding years to life alone…

but keeping life in those years.

Chapter 16 - Foods That Support the System

Eating for nourishment, balance and healthy ageing

Walk into a health store.

Scroll through social media.

You will soon meet the latest **"superfood."**

Chia seeds.

Quinoa.

Spirulina.

Berries.

Moringa.

And every few weeks, there seems to be a new food promising to do something extraordinary.

But let us pause for a moment.

Can one food really make you healthy?

Probably not.

Health is not created by one food.

It is created by the way your whole system works.

Your food.

Your digestion.

Your sleep.

Your movement.

Your stress.

Your habits.

And, importantly, whether what you eat actually suits you.

Food Is More Than Calories

We often look at food through numbers.

Calories.

Protein.

Carbohydrates.

Fat.

But food is much more than that.

Food provides nourishment.

It gives the body material to repair itself.

It affects digestion.

It influences energy.

It can make you feel light and energetic—or heavy and uncomfortable.

This is why Ayurveda has never looked at food simply as a list of calories.

It asks a different set of questions:

What food?

How much?

When?

How prepared?

And does it suit this person?

The same food may be wonderful for one person and uncomfortable for another.

The goal is not to find the perfect food.

It is to learn how to eat in a way that supports **your system**.

There Is No "Superfood"

The word *superfood* sounds impressive.

But it can also make healthy eating unnecessarily complicated.

One week, you are told to eat chia seeds.

The next week, some other food becomes the miracle answer.

Soon, healthy eating becomes another project.

You start wondering:

Am I eating the right food?

Did I miss the latest superfood?

Should I be taking this powder too?

Some foods are certainly more nutrient-rich than others.

But no single food can replace good habits, sensible eating, proper digestion, movement, sleep and a healthy lifestyle.

Balance matters more than chasing superfoods.

And this brings us to one traditional Indian food that deserves attention.

Then… Is There Anything Close to Amrit?

If Ayurveda speaks of *Amrit*—the nectar associated with nourishment, vitality and longevity—is there any natural food that comes close to that idea?

There is no need to turn this into a competition.

But one fruit deserves special attention.

Amla.

Or **Amalaki**.

Amla — The Mother Fruit

Amla has held a special place in Ayurveda for centuries.

One traditional Ayurvedic verse says:

"वयःस्थापनम् आमलकं श्रेष्ठम्"

Amalaki is among the best for maintaining youth and supporting healthy ageing.

That is a beautiful idea.

Amla is also known as **Dhatri**.

Dhatri means mother or nurse.

The name itself reflects the traditional understanding of Amla as something that nourishes and supports the body.

Amla is also an important ingredient in traditional Ayurvedic preparations such as **Triphala** and **Chyawanprash**, and is valued in the Ayurvedic tradition for rejuvenation and long-term wellbeing.

This is one reason Amla fits particularly well into our discussion of **health beyond weight**.

We are not eating Amla because we want to lose two kilograms.

We are talking about nourishment.

We are talking about supporting the body over the years.

We are talking about **healthy ageing**.

Why Is Amla So Interesting?

Ayurveda describes six tastes:

- Sweet
- Sour
- Salty

- Bitter
- Pungent
- Astringent

Amla is traditionally described as containing **five of these six tastes**, with salty being the exception.

It is also traditionally regarded as supportive of balance among the three doshas.

Whether or not you use Ayurvedic terminology in your everyday life, Amla has a long history of use in Indian health traditions.

Modern research has also taken considerable interest in Amla because of its naturally occurring nutrients and antioxidant compounds.

It is a good example of how an old food can remain relevant without becoming a social-media trend.

Amla and Healthy Ageing

As we grow older, the question changes.

When we are young, we often ask:

How do I look better?

Later, we begin asking:

How do I stay strong?

How do I keep my energy?

How do I remain independent?

How do I age well?

This is where traditional foods such as Amla become interesting.

Ayurveda has traditionally placed Amalaki among the foods and substances associated with **Rasayana**—the idea of nourishment, rejuvenation and maintaining vitality.

That does not mean Amla is a magic anti-ageing food.

It means that Ayurveda viewed certain foods as valuable not merely for satisfying hunger, but for supporting the body over the long term.

That is a much more useful way of thinking about food.

What About Honey?

A traditional combination is fresh Amla with a small amount of honey.

If you use honey, remember one simple traditional rule:

Do not heat honey.

Use it as it is, or with food or liquid that is comfortably warm rather than hot.

And remember:

More is not better.

A little is enough.

What About Triphala?

Triphala brings together three traditional fruits—**Amalaki, Bibhitaki and Haritaki**.

It has been used traditionally to support digestion and regular elimination.

For people who already use Triphala as part of their routine, a common traditional practice is to take it in the evening, often with warm water, before sleep.

But remember what we said earlier:

Triphala is not a shortcut to weight loss.

Its place is much broader.

It belongs to the traditional approach of supporting digestion and elimination—and those are part of a healthy system.

Choose Food That Supports You

This brings us back to the central idea of this chapter.

When you are trying to improve your health, don't ask only:

"Will this food make me lose weight?"

Ask:

"Will this food support my health?"

Will it digest well?

Does it suit me?

Does it give me nourishment?

Does it fit my lifestyle?

Can I continue eating this way without feeling miserable?

These are better questions.

A food may help you lose weight temporarily and still leave you tired, hungry and frustrated.

That is not the kind of health we are looking for.

Keep It Simple

You don't need a kitchen full of exotic ingredients.

You don't need expensive powders.

You don't need ten different seeds every morning.

You don't need to follow every food trend that appears on your phone.

Sometimes the best food is the simplest food.

Fresh vegetables.

Whole fruits.

Pulses.

Grains.

Nuts and seeds in sensible quantities.

Simple home-cooked meals.

Food that is familiar.

Food that suits you.

Food that you can eat consistently.

And sometimes, something as simple as a bowl of **khichdi** can be exactly what the body needs.

Simple does not mean inferior.

Simple often means sustainable.

Listen to Your Digestion

We have already talked about **Agni**—the digestive fire in the Ayurvedic understanding of health.

Here, we need only remember one practical lesson:

Don't judge food only by its reputation.

Watch your own response.

How do you feel after eating it?

Do you feel energetic?

Comfortable?

Light?

Or do you feel sleepy, bloated and heavy?

Your body is giving you information.

Learn to listen.

One Important Reminder

Healthy eating should make life better.

It should not become another source of anxiety.

You don't have to eat perfectly.

You don't have to fear every carbohydrate.

You don't have to reject every food you enjoy.

You don't have to search for a miracle ingredient.

And you certainly don't need to feel guilty because you ate something that wasn't on your “healthy” list.

Food is meant to nourish your life, not rule it.

Eat sensibly.

Eat consciously.

Keep your food simple.

Choose foods that suit you.

Let your overall lifestyle—not one magical food—do the real work.

The Takeaway

Don't chase superfoods.

Build better habits.

Build better balance.

And if you want to add one traditional food to your routine, **Amla is a beautiful place to start**—not because it is a weight-loss miracle, but because it represents something much bigger:

nourishment, vitality and healthy ageing.

Your goal was never simply to weigh less.

Your goal is to live well.

Chapter 17 - If You Don’t Have 1 Hour, Do This

Move in the Moments You Already Have

Most people don't stop taking care of their health because they are lazy.

Life simply gets full.

Work increases.

Travel happens.

Children need attention.

Deadlines arrive.

Sleep gets disturbed.

And exercise becomes something we keep postponing.

After this project.

After this trip.

When life becomes normal.

But life rarely becomes completely normal.

So instead of waiting for a perfect one-hour slot, use the moments that are already available.

You may have:

30 seconds.

1 minute.

3 minutes.

5 minutes.

This chapter is not a complete workout or a complicated routine.

It is simply a collection of practical ways to keep the body moving when time is limited.

Part 1 – The "Waiting Time" Exercises

Look carefully at your day.

You are probably waiting for:

- the lift
- tea to boil
- a download
- a phone call
- someone to arrive
- a meeting to begin
- traffic to move

Instead of standing completely still, wake up the body.

1. Engine Daud (Running Engine Burst)

Time: 30–60 seconds



Stand in one place.

Jog fast.

Lift your knees.

Pump your arms strongly, like a running engine.

Breathe actively.

This is a quick cardio burst that can:

- increase heart rate
- improve circulation
- create body heat
- wake you up
- reduce lethargy

Useful for:

- office breaks
- hotel rooms
- before bathing
- between work sessions

Short.

Powerful.

Practical.

2. Lift-Wait Calf Raises

Time: 30–40 seconds



While waiting:

Lift your heels up and down repeatedly.

This simple movement activates the calves and can help reduce stiffness from prolonged sitting.

It is especially useful for:

- office workers
- older adults
- people who sit for long hours

Nobody even needs to know that your waiting time has quietly become movement time.

3. Invisible Squats

Time: 30–45 seconds



Stand comfortably.

Bend your knees and hips as though you are about to sit on an invisible chair.

Come back up.

Repeat slowly.

Even **5–10 repetitions** can provide useful movement.

This works on:

- leg strength
- mobility
- functional movement
- balance

Strong, functional legs become increasingly important as we age.

Part 2 – The "Chair Cardio" System

Many of us spend a large part of the day sitting.

You may not always be able to get up and walk around.

But you can still interrupt prolonged sitting.

4. Chair Cardio

Time: 1–3 minutes



Sit towards the edge of a stable chair.

Now:

- extend your arms and legs outward together
- bring them back in
- repeat rhythmically

Add active breathing.

You can also:

- lift your knees rapidly
- twist gently from side to side
- punch forward lightly

This can be useful during:

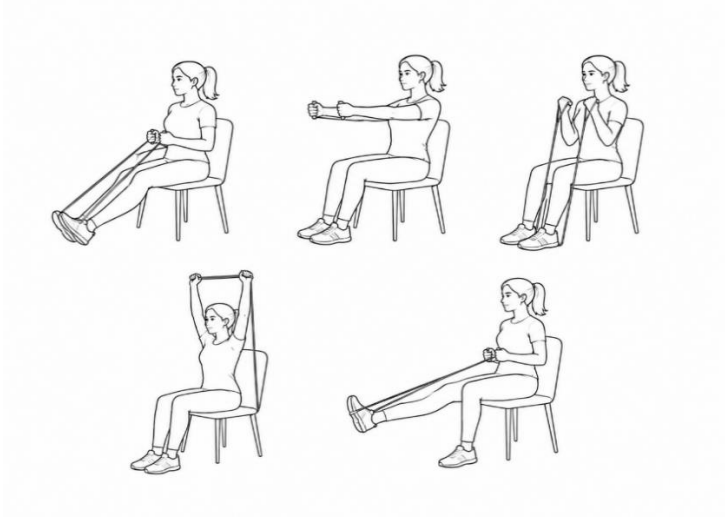
- office work
- travel
- meetings
- airport waiting
- television watching

The idea is simple:

Don't let sitting become completely uninterrupted.

5. TV-Time Resistance Band Routine

Time: 2–5 minutes



Keep a resistance band near the sofa.

When you are watching television, use a few minutes for movement.

Try:

- pulling the band apart slowly
- seated rows

- overhead presses
- gentle chest-opening movements

No great intensity is required.

Just movement.

This can help maintain:

- posture
- joint movement
- muscle activation
- everyday mobility

This becomes particularly useful as we get older and naturally begin to lose muscle strength.

A Small Insight

The best exercise equipment is often the one already visible in the room.

If the resistance band is hidden in a cupboard, it is easy to forget.

If it is beside the sofa, using it becomes much easier.

6. Walking With Light Weights

Time: 1–5 minutes



While walking at home, you can carry light dumbbells or water bottles.

Walk naturally.

You can also add simple movements such as:

- gentle curls
- shoulder movements
- controlled arm raises

This adds light resistance to ordinary movement.

There is no need for:

- workout clothes
- a gym
- special preparation

However, if carrying weights affects your balance or makes walking uncomfortable, simply walk without them.

The walking itself is valuable.

Part 3 – The Digestive Fire Practices

The next two practices are different.

They come from yogic traditions that use deliberate abdominal control and are traditionally associated with stimulating **Agni—the digestive fire**.

These are **not casual "anytime" exercises.**

Learn them properly from an experienced yoga teacher and practise them according to the appropriate precautions. They are generally practised on an empty stomach.

7. Uddiyana Bandha

Time: 20–30 seconds



Stand comfortably.

Exhale completely.

Now gently draw the abdomen inward and upward beneath the ribs.

Hold briefly.

Relax slowly.

Uddiyana Bandha is a traditional yogic practice involving conscious control of the abdominal region.

It should be learnt correctly rather than copied casually.

Avoid this practice in situations where it is unsuitable, including pregnancy, hernia, ulcers or uncontrolled blood pressure. If you have a specific health condition, discuss its suitability with an appropriate healthcare professional before practising it.

8. Agnisar Kriya

Time: 20–40 seconds



Exhale completely.

Hold the breath out gently.

Now move the abdomen repeatedly in and out according to the technique taught by your teacher.

Relax afterward.

Traditional yogic systems use Agnisar to stimulate **Agni—the digestive fire**.

Practitioners may experience:

- lightness
- warmth
- abdominal activation
- a feeling of increased energy

But this is a practice to **learn**, not something to imitate casually.

It should be learnt under the guidance of an experienced teacher and practised on an appropriately empty stomach.

Part 4 – The "No Excuse" Movement Tools

These are for the days when you are:

- busy
- travelling
- tired
- emotionally low
- simply not in the mood for a full workout

The goal is not perfection.

The goal is to do something.

9. Phone Call Walking

Time: Depends on the call



Take some calls while walking.

Not all.

Just a few.

If a call doesn't require you to sit in front of a screen, walk while talking.

Walk around your home.

Walk around the office.

Walk somewhere safe while continuing your conversation.

A few minutes may not seem like much.

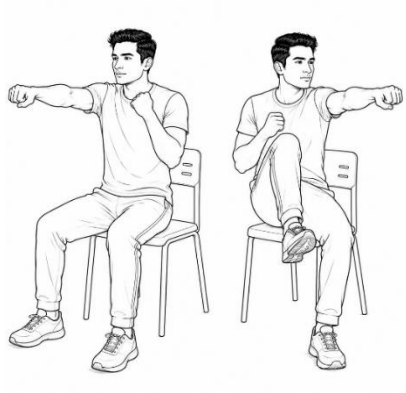
But repeated over weeks and months, those minutes add up.

You didn't have to “find exercise time.”

You simply used time that already existed.

10. Seated Boxing + Knee Lifts

Time: 1 minute



Sit on a stable chair or stand comfortably.

Punch the air quickly while lifting your knees alternately.

Fast.

Playful.

Energetic.

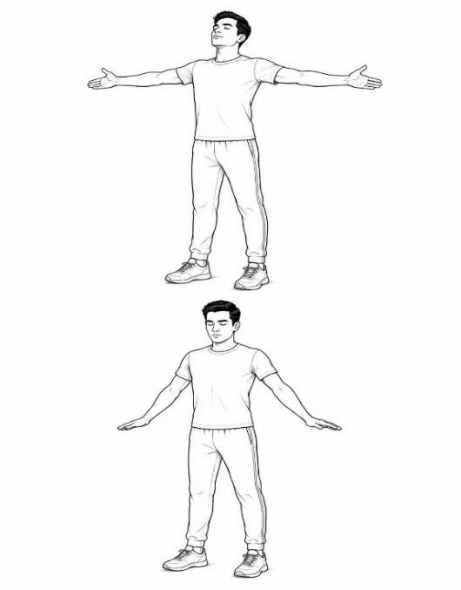
This gets the whole body moving and can be useful during:

- television breaks
- work fatigue
- mental dullness

Sometimes the body needs a little movement before the mind feels ready to work again.

11. Breath Expansion Reset

Time: 30–60 seconds



Stand tall.

Stretch your arms outward while inhaling deeply.

Expand the chest comfortably.

Now exhale slowly while bringing the arms inward.

Repeat rhythmically.

This simple practice brings attention to:

- posture
- breathing
- energy
- mental clarity

Sometimes the body simply feels compressed after hours of sitting, concentrating and working.

Take a minute.

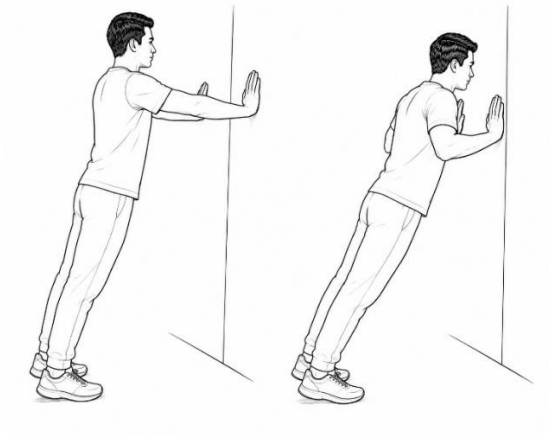
Open the body.

Breathe.

Reset.

12. Wall Push-Ups

Time: 30–60 seconds



Stand facing a wall.

Place your hands against it at about chest height.

Bend your elbows and bring your body towards the wall.

Push yourself back.

Repeat.

Wall push-ups are useful for:

- beginners
- older adults
- office workers
- people returning to exercise
- travel days

They provide simple upper-body resistance without requiring you to get down onto the floor.

Choose One

You don't have to do everything in this chapter.

Choose **one** practice.

Try it for:

30 seconds.

Or:

1 minute.

That's enough to begin.

Tomorrow, you can choose another.

The point is not to complete a perfect routine.

It is to make movement easier to fit into ordinary life.

A Line Worth Remembering

Thirty seconds of movement is better than zero.

And sometimes:

Even one minute of movement can make a difference.

Final Thought

You don't need a perfect routine to stay active.

Use the moments you already have.

While waiting.

During a phone call.

Beside the sofa.

Between meetings.

In a hotel room.

At home.

Move when you can.

Health is not built only during dedicated exercise sessions.

It is also built in the small spaces between everything else that life asks you to do.

Sometimes, you don't need an hour.

You just need a minute.

Chapter 18 - No More Drama

A healthier way to live, without perfection or punishment

Where You Began

You started this journey with a simple question:

"How do I lose weight?"

Perhaps you had already tried diets, exercise plans, restrictions, challenges and motivation.

You started.

You stopped.

You started again.

And somewhere along the way, you began to believe that the problem was **you**.

Maybe you thought you were not disciplined enough.

Not consistent enough.

Not motivated enough.

But this book has shown you something different.

What You Have Discovered

Your body was never your enemy.

It was responding to the way you were living.

To your food.

Your movement.

Your sleep.

Your stress.

Your breathing.

Your routines.

And when life became disturbed, your body responded to that too.

So the answer was not to **fight your body harder**.

It was to understand it better.

And support it.

You Don't Need to Complicate Health

You have learned that health is not one magic food, one exercise, one diet or one perfect routine.

It is the result of many ordinary things working together.

What you eat matters.

How much you eat matters.

How you eat matters.

When you eat matters.

Your body also needs movement, strength, rest, sleep, breathing, relaxation and recovery.

Not perfectly.

Regularly.

That is the difference.

Small Things Become Big Things

You don't need an hour every day to care for your health.

You can walk.

Stretch.

Take the stairs.

Move while waiting.

Do a few simple exercises.

Breathe more consciously.

Eat a little more mindfully.

Sleep a little better.

These things may look small.

But health is built from things that are repeated.

Small actions become habits.

And habits quietly become a way of life.

You Also Learned to Stop Starting Over

Perhaps this is the most important lesson.

Missing a day does not erase your progress.

Eating something you had not planned does not mean the day is ruined.

A busy week does not mean you have failed.

Life will interrupt your routine.

That's normal.

The answer is not:

“I will start again on Monday.”

It is simply:

“I will continue from here.”

You are not starting again.

You are continuing.

Health Is Bigger Than the Scale

Weight matters.

But it is not the whole story.

Health is also about:

having more energy,

moving more comfortably,

sleeping better,

feeling stronger,

managing stress,

maintaining independence,

enjoying food without fear,

and being able to participate fully in life.

The number on the scale is only one part of that picture.

Health is the bigger story.

Be a Little More Like a Child

Perhaps there is something else we can learn from children.

They move.

They play.

They laugh.

They rest.

They eat.

They forget.

And then they continue living.

They don't turn every movement into an exercise target.

They don't feel guilty about enjoying themselves.

They don't try to perform health perfectly.

Maybe we don't need to either.

Move more freely.

Laugh a little louder.

Dance sometimes.

Walk sometimes.

Play.

Rest when you need to.

Enjoy your life while improving it.

There Is No Race

Your body has its own history.

Your circumstances are different.

Your journey will not look like someone else's.

So stop comparing your progress with social media, transformation photographs or someone else's timeline.

Go at a pace you can live with.

Because the best health routine is not the one you can follow for thirty days.

It is the one that can quietly become part of your life.

From Tomorrow

Tomorrow morning, you don't need to begin a completely new life.

Just make one or two choices a little differently.

Drink your water.

Take a deeper breath.

Move a little more.

Eat with awareness.

Sleep a little better.

Laugh a little more.

And when you have a difficult day?

Don't punish yourself.

Don't give up.

Return.

Then continue.

The Simple Truth

You do not need to fight your body.

Work with it.

You do not need perfection.

Choose continuity.

You do not need extreme routines.

Build habits that fit into real life.

And you don't need to make health another source of stress.

Health should make life better.

Final Thought

Health was never meant to feel like punishment.

It was meant to become part of life.

So breathe deeply.

Move naturally.

Eat simply.

Sleep properly.

Laugh freely.

Rest when needed.

And keep returning to the things that make you healthier.

Not perfectly.

Not dramatically.

Just consistently.

Because you are not beginning a new life.

You are learning to live your existing life a little better.

And perhaps that is the real meaning of:

No More Drama.



About the Author

Pradeep Solanki is a corporate wellness expert, yoga trainer, and wellness educator with over 15 years of experience in yoga, workplace wellness, and holistic health.

After spending years in the high-pressure corporate world and experiencing firsthand the effects of stress, chronic back pain, and lifestyle imbalance, he turned toward yoga, breathwork, mindful movement, and holistic living—not as extreme solutions, but as practical tools for everyday life.

Through his wellness initiative, Yoga On Call, Pradeep has conducted thousands of wellness sessions for 1,000+ companies across 100+ cities, helping professionals bring simple and sustainable wellness practices into their everyday lives. His work focuses on making wellness practical, accessible, and relevant to the realities of modern work and family life.

Pradeep is also the founder of The Healing Mat, an initiative created to make quality yoga and wellness more accessible through affordable daily online classes for individuals.

His approach is deliberately different from rigid dieting, punishment-based exercise, and unrealistic fitness expectations. He believes that lasting health is built through practical changes in everyday life—better movement, breathing, food choices, sleep, recovery, stress management, and consistency.

He is also the author of *Mastering Corporate Yoga*, a practical handbook for yoga trainers and wellness professionals working in corporate environments.

Through his work, Pradeep continues to bridge traditional yogic wisdom with the realities of modern life, helping people move toward better health with greater awareness, simplicity, and less drama.

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- M.A. in Yogic Sciences
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- YCB – Level 3
- Certified Laughter Yoga Leader
- B.Tech Computer Science
- LL.B.
- Post Graduate Diploma in Human Rights

For Feedback or Suggestions

If you have feedback, suggestions, or thoughts about this book, I would be happy to hear from you.

Email: solankipr@gmail.com

Yoga On Call: www.yogaoncall.com

The Healing Mat: www.thehealingmat.yoga

A Small Request

If you received a free copy of this book, I hope you find it useful — or that it helps someone you care about.

If you would like to support my work, you are welcome to contribute any amount you wish.

Your support helps me continue sharing the message of good health with more people.

Thank you.

Support the Author



Contribute any amount you wish.

ABOUT THE BOOK

What if losing weight didn't have to feel like a full-time job?

Weight Loss Without the Drama challenges the idea that better health requires extreme diets, punishing workouts, rigid routines or tremendous willpower.

It takes a simpler approach: small changes across everyday life.

Food | Movement | Sleep | Breathing | Stress | Habits



No perfection. No starting over every Monday.
No obsession with the weighing scale.

This is not a book about becoming someone else.
It is about making your existing life a little healthier — with less effort, less guilt and a lot less drama.

Less effort. Better habits. A healthier life.

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Pradeep Solanki is a corporate wellness expert, yoga professional and wellness educator with 15+ years of experience in yoga and workplace wellness.

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Health should fit into life — not take over it.

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